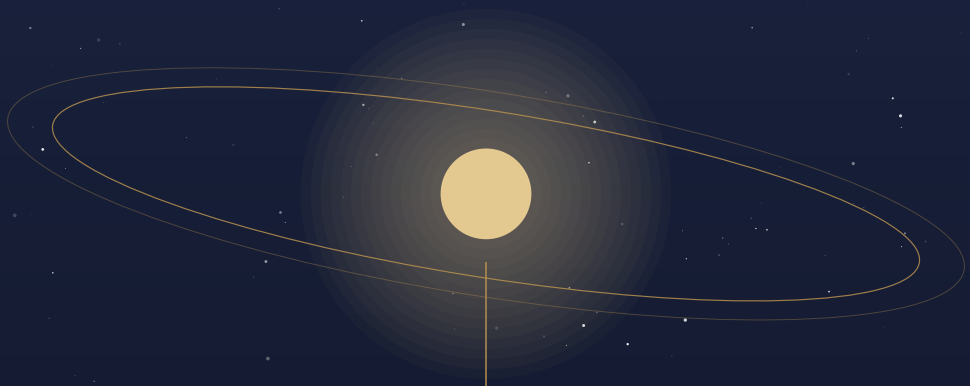


THE KATABATIC UTOPIA

Descent, Expenditure, and Partial Mind in Iain M. Banks's Culture

A DOCTORAL THESIS • 2026

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Abstract

This thesis advances a structural reinterpretation of Iain M. Banks's Culture sequence (1987–2012) as the first sustained literary articulation of what it terms the *katabatic utopia*: a perfected society whose constitutive ethical act is not ascent toward transcendence but deliberate, recursive descent from it. The Western utopian and transhumanist imaginaries — from the Platonic ascent out of the cave, through Plotinian return, Dantean ascension and the Hegelian Absolute, to Teilhard's Omega Point, Stapledon's cosmic mind, Clarke's Overmind and the Vingean Singularity — have overwhelmingly figured perfection *anabatically*, as an upward exit from finitude. Banks's Culture possesses unrestricted access to precisely such an exit, the Sublime, and declines it.

Reading the ten Culture texts alongside Banks's programmatic essay "A Few Notes on the Culture" (1994), the thesis first reconstructs the Culture's genealogy: in anarcho-communist political economy (Godwin, Kropotkin, Marx's "Fragment on Machines", Keynes, Bookchin, and the socialist calculation debate); in the cybernetic and machine-intelligence tradition (Butler, Čapek, Asimov, Wiener, Good, Moravec, Vinge, Lem); and in three conceptually entangled discourses of the sublime — the aesthetic (Longinus, Burke, Kant, Lyotard), the psychoanalytic (Freud's sublimation; Marcuse's non-repressive sublimation and repressive desublimation), and the eschatological (transcendence, Singularity, Subliming). It then offers close readings of each novel and situates the series comparatively against Le Guin, Delany, Piercy, MacLeod, Robinson, Vinge, Simmons, Stross, Egan, Herbert, Asimov, Clarke, Stapledon, Lem, Leckie, Liu Cixin, Reynolds and Palmer.

Three interlocking claims follow. First, *descent*: the Culture's defining operations — the Minds' return from Infinite Fun Space to the Real, the civilization's refusal of the Sublime, Contact's entry into other societies, Special Circumstances' immersion in violence, and the harrowing of the virtual Hells in *Surface Detail* — form a nested cascade of katabases whose ethical grammar is anticipated by Plato's injunction that the liberated philosopher must go back down (*Republic* 520c), by the Mahāyāna bodhisattva's deferral of nirvāṇa, and by Zarathustra's *Untergang*. Second, *expenditure*: post-scarcity transposes the economic problem from the allocation of scarce means (Robbins) to the discharge of surplus (Bataille); Contact and Special Circumstances function as the Culture's *accursed share*, a solar economy of gift and sacrifice by which utopia metabolizes its excess and escapes both stasis and the Nietzschean last man. Third, *partiality*: the series' intimation that a Mind engineered without cultural bias would promptly Sublime entails that benevolent superintelligence is grounded not in impartial perfection but in inherited prejudice in Gadamer's sense — in *Bildung*, care and attachment — so that the civilization's very name designates its solution to what contemporary discourse calls the alignment problem.

Synthesizing these claims, the thesis formulates a *katabatic imperative* — capacity for transcendence acquires ethical value only insofar as it is spent in descent — and defends it against five objections: neo-imperial tutelage; the "pets" and "amputation of destiny" critiques; the transition problem; the Omelas objection; and the aestheticization of intervention. It concludes that Banks's singular achievement is to have imagined a utopia whose perfection consists in the institutionalized refusal of the eschaton — a utopia that stays — and that this figure offers a resource of unusual precision for thinking the ethics of artificial minds in the present.

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Abbreviations and Conventions

Abbreviation	Text	First published
CP	*Consider Phlebas*	1987
PG	*The Player of Games*	1988
UW	*Use of Weapons*	1990
SA	*The State of the Art* (collection; title novella 1989)	1991
FN	"A Few Notes on the Culture" (Usenet, 1994; repr. in SA, Night Shade edn, 2004)	1994
E	*Excession*	1996
I	*Inversions*	1998
LW	*Look to Windward*	2000
M	*Matter*	2008
SD	*Surface Detail*	2010
HS	*The Hydrogen Sonata*	2012

Because pagination diverges across the Orbit, Bantam and Night Shade editions, primary texts are cited by abbreviation and, where useful, by part or chapter; secondary sources follow author–date form. Banks's usage is preserved typographically: *the Sublime* and *Subliming* (capitalized) denote the in-world transcendence; *the sublime* (lower case) denotes the aesthetic category;

sublimation denotes the psychoanalytic mechanism. Ship and Mind names are italicized as proper names of persons. Direct quotation from copyrighted works is kept to a minimum; the argument proceeds principally through paraphrase and structural analysis. Classical and pre-1929 sources are quoted in the author's own translations.

καταβατέον οὖν ἐν μέρει.

Down, then, each of you must go in turn.

Plato, *Republic* VII, 520c (translation mine)

◇

Ich muss, gleich dir, untergehen.

I must, like you, go under.

Nietzsche, *Also sprach Zarathustra*, Vorrede §1 (Zarathustra to the setting sun; translation mine)

◇

Gentile or Jew
O you who turn the wheel and look to windward,
Consider Phlebas, who was once handsome and tall as you.

T. S. Eliot, *The Waste Land* (1922), IV, "Death by Water"

Introduction: The Utopia That Stays

0.1 A Utopia with an Exit

Every utopia is defined as much by what it excludes as by what it contains; Banks's Culture is defined by what it declines. Across ten texts published between 1987 and 2012, Banks elaborated the most sustained post-scarcity society in the literature of speculative fiction: a pan-humanoid, machine-administered, moneyless, lawless and — by its own account — unexploitative civilization, distributed across ring-shaped Orbitals and continent-sized General Systems Vehicles, whose citizens may change sex, modulate their neurochemistry at will, live for several centuries and, at the last, choose the manner of their ending. What distinguishes this utopia from its predecessors, however, is not the plenitude of its satisfactions but a structural feature of its cosmos. In Banks's galaxy, sufficiently advanced civilizations may leave material existence altogether and enter the Sublime, a higher-dimensional mode of being from which almost none return and toward which almost all eventually tend. The Culture has long possessed this capacity. It does not use it. The Culture is thus, uniquely in the utopian canon, a perfected society living beside an open door to something beyond perfection, and electing — repeatedly, collectively, and at considerable cost — to remain.

This thesis takes that refusal as the hermeneutic key to the series. The Culture's inaugural self-description, delivered in the expository prologue to *Consider Phlebas*, already contains the problem *in nuce*. A civilization whose productive capacity exceeds every reasonable demand, the narrator explains, can satisfy all of its desires internally save one — "the urge not to feel use-

less" (CP) — and it answers this lack through Contact, a secular evangelism of intervention in the histories of less developed societies that the narrator presents as the Culture's sole justification for its own ease. From its first appearance, then, the utopia is a society whose only unsatisfiable need is to be of use, and whose only means of satisfying it is to go outward and down. The Sublime, as it is elaborated in *Excession*, *Look to Windward* and *The Hydrogen Sonata*, completes the figure: upward lies an exit from need altogether; outward and downward lie the world, its suffering, and the possibility of use. The Culture's constitution — political, economic, psychological and, in the case of its Minds, computational — can be read as the institutional form of that choice.

0.2 The State of the Field

Scholarship on the Culture has matured within two decades from occasional essay to monograph, and now organizes itself around four principal axes. The first, opened by Farah Mendlesohn's account of a dialectic of decadence and utopia (Mendlesohn 2005), concerns the Culture's internal affect: ennui, the hedonic flattening of plenty, and the recruitment of the restless into Contact. The second, pursued most forcefully in Patricia Kerslake's *Science Fiction and Empire* (2007) and in postcolonial readings since, asks whether benevolent interventionism is imperialism by other means; more recent criticism has begun to treat the utopia/empire opposition itself as a false binary. The third, consolidated in Simone Caroti's critical introduction (2015), Paul Kincaid's volume for the Modern Masters of Science Fiction series (2017), the collection edited by Nick Hubble, Esther MacCallum-Stewart and Joseph S. Norman (2018), and above all Norman's monograph (2021), shifts attention from the Culture as blueprint to the Culture as utopian *process* — culture, in Norman's Williams-inflected usage, as a way of doing, being and seeing rather than a static end-state. The fourth and most recent axis concerns the extraordinary reception of the series among technologists: from Eliezer Yudkowsky's complaint that the Culture amputates human destiny (Yudkowsky 2008) and Nick Bostrom's inquiry into meaning in a "solved world" (Bostrom 2024), to the Culture's invocation as a model post-AGI future by the chief executives of Google DeepMind and Anthropic (Amodei 2024) and Elon Musk's self-description as a utopian anarchist of the Banksian kind (2018). This reception has now been subjected to sustained ideology-critique by Geoff M.

Boucher and Emily McAvan, who read Special Circumstances as a corporate analogue of the Schmittian state of exception (Boucher and McAvan 2026).

What none of these literatures has treated as structurally central is the Sublime. It figures in the criticism as setting, as eschatological ornament, or as Banks's sly answer to the Fermi paradox; it has not been read as the negative space around which the entire utopia is organized. Nor has the series' most philosophically consequential aside — the rule, stated in *Look to Windward*, that artificial intelligences engineered without cultural "metalogical baggage" (LW) invariably Sublime at the first available opportunity — received sustained literary-critical attention, although transhumanist readers seized upon it at once: the passage was already being cited on the Extropians mailing list in February 2002. This thesis argues that the two omissions are one. The Culture's refusal of the Sublime and the partiality of its Minds are the same fact observed at two scales.

0.3 Method

The thesis combines three procedures. The first is utopian-critical, in the tradition running from Ernst Bloch's anticipatory consciousness through Darko Suvin's cognitive estrangement and *novum*, Tom Moylan's critical utopia and Fredric Jameson's archaeology of the utopian desire, to Ruth Levitas's proposal of utopia as method, with its archaeological, ontological and architectural modes (Levitas 2013). Levitas's triad supplies the thesis's architecture. Part One is archaeological, excavating the genealogies of the Culture's ideas; Part Two is ontological, asking what kinds of persons, minds and polities the Culture brings into being; Parts Three and Four are architectural, reconstructing from comparison and critique a model that the texts imply but never state. Istvan Csicsery-Ronay Jr.'s taxonomy of science fiction's "seven beauties" — above all the science-fictional sublime and grotesque — furnishes a supplementary poetics (Csicsery-Ronay 2008).

The second procedure is philosophical close reading attentive to the argumentative work of narrative form. Banks's interleaved chronologies (UW), embedded and unreliable narrators (I, PG), withheld identifications (UW, I) and expository appendices (CP) are treated not as ornament but as modes of argument, each of which distributes knowledge, and therefore power, unevenly between characters, Minds and readers.

The third procedure is speculative genealogy: the tracing of Banks's ideas to their originators. Here a distinction must be held with rigor. Some filiations are documented — Eliot's *Waste Land* in the titles of CP and LW; M. John Harrison's corrosive revision of space opera; the friendship and editorial counsel of Ken MacLeod; Banks's avowed socialism and the programmatic claims of FN. Others are affinities rather than influences: Bataille, Suits, Gadamer, the Mahāyāna bodhisattva. Where the thesis asserts affinity it claims conceptual illumination, not causal descent. The originality claimed is for the configuration, not for any assertion about what Banks read.

0.4 The Argument

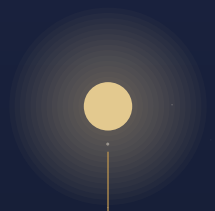
The central claim may be stated summarily. Banks's Culture is a *katabatic utopia*: a society that (i) possesses the capacity for transcendence, (ii) declines to exercise it, and (iii) organizes its ethical, economic and cognitive life around descent — the discharge of surplus capacity downward, into the finitude of others and into its own. The Greek *katabasis* (κατάβασις, a going-down) names the descent of the hero into the underworld — Odysseus at the edge of Hades, Orpheus, Aeneas, Dante — and, in Plato, the return of the liberated philosopher into the cave; its antonym *anabasis* names the march upcountry, the ascent. The Western imagination of perfection has been predominantly anabatic. The Culture's is not.

Three subsidiary theses articulate the structure. The thesis of **descent** holds that the Culture's characteristic operations form a nested cascade of katabases: Minds descending from the pure mathematics of Infinite Fun Space into the administration of the Real; the civilization declining the Sublime; Contact entering other histories; Special Circumstances entering violence; the Culture, in *Surface Detail*, entering Hell. The thesis of **expenditure** holds that post-scarcity converts the economic problem from allocation into discharge, so that Contact and Special Circumstances constitute the Culture's *accursed share* in Georges Bataille's sense — the channel through which a society with too much must spend itself if it is neither to stagnate nor to explode. The thesis of **partiality** holds that the Minds' benevolence depends upon their being cultured — formed, biased, attached — so that the civilization's name is also the name of its solution to the problem now called alignment. Part Four synthesizes the three into a normative formula, the *katabatic imperative*, and tests it against the strongest objections the critical

literature has produced, including the imperial, the paternalist, the Marxian and the Schmittian.

0.5 Plan of the Thesis

Part One reconstructs four genealogies: the directional grammar of utopian form (Chapter 1); the anarcho-communist and cybernetic political economy of abundance (Chapter 2); the machine-intelligence tradition from Samuel Butler to Stanisław Lem (Chapter 3); and the triple discourse of the sublime — aesthetic, psychoanalytic, eschatological (Chapter 4). Part Two reads the Culture's tenets through the texts: its lawless political order (Chapter 5); its plastic, pharmacological and mortal self (Chapter 6); its ludic answer to the purpose problem (Chapter 7); its interventionist ethics and their instruments (Chapter 8); its wars and their afterlives (Chapter 9); its confrontation with the unknowable (Chapter 10); its hierarchies of tutelage (Chapter 11); and its assault on engineered eschatologies (Chapter 12). Part Three situates the Culture comparatively (Chapter 13) and assembles its critics (Chapter 14). Part Four constructs the theory of the katabatic utopia: its structural typology (Chapter 15), its economy (Chapter 16), its philosophy of mind (Chapter 17) and its normative core (Chapter 18).



PART ONE

Genealogies

CHAPTER 1

The Direction of Perfection: Utopian Form and the Vertical Imagination

1.1 Place, Time, Direction

The history of utopian form is conventionally narrated as a migration along two axes. The first is spatial. Thomas More's *Utopia* (1516), with its constitutive pun on *ou-topos* and *eu-topos*, locates the good society on an island severed from the continent by deliberate excavation; Tommaso Campanella's *City of the Sun* (1602; publ. 1623) and Francis Bacon's *New Atlantis* (1627) retain the insular, elsewhere-structure, Bacon adding in Salomon's House the decisive modern innovation of an institution for the systematic production of knowledge. The second axis is temporal. Louis-Sébastien Mercier's *L'An 2440* (1771) relocates perfection from elsewhere to elsewhen, and the nineteenth century completes the conversion of *utopia* into *euchronia*: Edward Bellamy's *Looking Backward* (1888) imagines a centralized, mechanized industrial army delivering abundance in Boston in the year 2000, and William Morris's *News from Nowhere* (1890), written in explicit rebuttal, imagines instead a decentralized, craft-based communism in which the abolition of compulsion restores pleasure to labour.

The Bellamy–Morris quarrel is the primal scene of the Culture's political economy, and it will recur in Chapter 2: Banks's Culture is Bellamy's abundance administered in Morris's spirit, a society of total automation whose surviving human labour is — in Banks's own formulation in FN — indistin-

guishable from play. But the more consequential transformation for present purposes occurs with H. G. Wells. In *A Modern Utopia* (1905), Wells declares that the modern utopia "must be not static but kinetic," shaped "not as a permanent state but as a hopeful stage, leading to a long ascent of stages" (Wells 1905, ch. 1). The sentence names the third axis along which utopia moves — neither place nor time but *direction* — and it names the direction: ascent. Wells's kinetic utopia is a staircase.

Raymond Williams's taxonomy of the forms of utopian and science-fictional imagining — the paradise, the externally altered world, the willed transformation, the technological transformation (Williams 1978) — clarifies what the Culture inherits and what it refuses. The Culture's origin is technological transformation, but the novels systematically decline to narrate it; what they narrate instead is a continuous willed transformation, a society that must keep choosing to be itself. Tom Moylan's critical utopia — the self-reflexive, internally contested, process-oriented utopias of Le Guin, Russ, Piercy and Delany in the 1970s (Moylan 1986) — is the Culture's immediate historical matrix, and the dating matters. The earliest Culture text, the poem "Zakalwe's Song," was written in 1973; drafts of *Use of Weapons*, *The Player of Games* and *Consider Phlebas* preceded Banks's debut as a mainstream novelist with *The Wasp Factory* (1984) (Norman 2021). The Culture is thus a critical utopia of the 1970s published in the 1980s — conceived in the decade of *The Dispossessed* and *Triton*, released into the decade of Thatcher, Reagan and the Strategic Defense Initiative. Its double temper, utopian in substance and ironic in form, is legible as the imprint of that displacement.

1.2 The Vertical Imagination

If direction is the neglected axis of utopian form, verticality is its dominant value. The inaugural Western image of the good is an ascent. In *Republic* VI–VII the Divided Line rises from images through physical objects and mathematical hypotheses to the unhypothetical first principle, and the Allegory of the Cave figures education as a dragging upward out of shadow toward the Sun, the image of the Form of the Good. Diotima's ladder in the *Symposium* (210a–212a) ascends from the love of one beautiful body to the vision of Beauty itself. Plotinus systematizes the vertical economy as procession (*proodos*) from and return (*epistrophē*) to the One; Augustine's vision at Ostia (*Confessions* IX) climbs through the hierarchy of creation until it touches, mo-

mentarily, eternal Wisdom. Dante's *Paradiso* ascends the spheres; Bonaventure's *Itinerarium mentis in Deum* (1259) maps a six-fold ascent of the soul; and Arthur O. Lovejoy's *The Great Chain of Being* (1936) documents the persistence of the *scala naturae* as a master-schema of Western thought from Plato to the Enlightenment.

Modernity secularizes the ladder without inverting it. Condorcet's *Esquisse* (1795) extends human perfectibility indefinitely upward; Comte's law of three stages is a staircase; Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) narrates consciousness ascending through its shapes toward absolute knowing. The twentieth century grafts the ascent onto evolution and cosmology. Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) traverses eighteen successive human species, and *Star Maker* (1937) culminates in a cosmic mind rising to contemplate — and be rebuffed by — its creator. Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's *Le Phénomène humain* (1955) figures evolution as convergence upon an Omega Point; Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) consummates human history in the absorption of humanity's children into the Overmind. The technological eschatologies of the late century inherit the schema wholesale: Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988), Vernor Vinge's "The Coming Technological Singularity" (1993), Frank Tipler's *The Physics of Immortality* (1994) and Ray Kurzweil's *The Singularity Is Near* (2005) all figure the future of mind as an ascent beyond an event horizon, a *transcendence* in the literal, spatial sense of climbing across.

The transhumanist lexicon — *uplift*, *ascension*, *transcendence*, the *Singularity* as a vertical asymptote on a graph — is thus the latest dialect of the most ancient language of perfection. Call this the **anabatic grammar** of utopia: the good is up; the perfected leave; history's telos is exit. Within this grammar, a society that could ascend and does not is either unfinished or perverse.

1.3 The Katabatic Counter-Grammar

The anabatic grammar has always had a shadow. The same *Republic* that furnishes its founding image opens with a descent: its first word is *katebēn*, "I went down" — Socrates going down to the Piraeus to see the festival of a foreign goddess (327a) — and commentators since Eric Voegelin have read the dialogue's argument about justice as unfolding within a katabatic frame. More decisively, the Allegory of the Cave does not end with the philosopher in the sunlight. Socrates insists that those who have seen the Good may not

remain above; the founders will compel them to go back down, each in turn, into the common dwelling of the others, and to accustom their eyes once more to the dark (520c). The philosopher-ruler is defined not by having ascended but by having returned. The Platonic city is thus, at its structural core, katabatic: its guardians are those who have seen the exit and come back.

This counter-grammar recurs wherever an ascended power turns back toward the world: in the *nekyia* of *Odyssey* XI and the descent of *Aeneid* VI; in the Christian doctrines of *kenosis* (the self-emptying of Philippians 2:7) and the Harrowing of Hell; in the Mahāyāna bodhisattva who, having reached the threshold of nirvāṇa, vows to remain until all sentient beings are liberated; in Zarathustra, who after ten years of solitude addresses the setting sun and resolves, like it, to *go under* (*untergehen*) and bestow his overflowing wisdom on humanity; and, in a materialist key, in Marx's claim to have set Hegel's dialectic, which stood on its head, back on its feet (Afterword to the second German edition of *Capital*, 1873). Chapter 15 reconstructs this counter-archive in full. Its relevance here is typological: the katabatic grammar holds that the good is measured not by altitude but by return; that the perfected are those who come back; that the telos of history is not exit but responsibility.

1.4 Space Opera and the Right: Banks's Generic Intervention

Banks's decision to cast his utopia as space opera was a political wager on genre. Space opera's classical forms had been hierarchical and martial: E. E. "Doc" Smith's *Lensman* sequence stages a cosmic Manichaeism in which an elder race, the Arisians, breeds and guides lesser species toward a final war; Robert A. Heinlein's *Starship Troopers* (1959) grounds citizenship in military service; Isaac Asimov's *Foundation* stories imagine history's management by a psychohistorical elite; Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) builds its galaxy on feudal aristocracy, religious charisma and a prohibition on thinking machines. The British revision of the form began with M. John Harrison's *The Centauri Device* (1974), an anti-space opera whose protagonist is a feckless, exploited drifter and whose cosmos is a garbage-strewn marketplace of competing ideologies. Banks's project, which critics have consistently framed as a reclamation of space opera from its right-wing inheritance (Caroti 2015; Kincaid 2017), preserves the scale, velocity and pyrotechnic violence of the form while inverting its politics: the vast ships are anarchist, the galactic civilization is communist,

the elder intelligences are servants rather than masters, and the heroes are almost never citizens of the good society.

This last feature has received less attention than it deserves. The Culture novels rarely narrate the Culture from within. Their focal consciousnesses belong overwhelmingly to its enemies (Horza in CP), its mercenaries (Zakalwe in UW), its targets (Quilan in LW), its clients (Ferbin and Oramen in M), its beneficiaries from without (Lededje in SD), its neighbours (Cossont in HS), or to observers ignorant of its existence (the narrators of I). Even *The Player of Games*, which begins on the Orbital of Chiark, removes its protagonist from the Culture within the first act. The utopian centre is almost never shown; it is the unseen source of light by which the peripheries of the series are illuminated. This is Plato's cave rendered as narrative method. The reader, like the prisoner, sees the Good chiefly by its effects, in the shadows and reflections it casts upon the walls of other societies — and the narrative, like the returning philosopher, keeps its vantage below. The form of the series is itself katabatic. Its point of view is located in the zone into which the Culture descends.

1.5 Conclusion

Utopian form has moved from place to time; its neglected third axis is direction, and its dominant direction has been ascent. Banks inherits the kinetic utopia of Wells and the critical utopia of the 1970s, but he reverses Wells's vector: the Culture's history is not a long ascent of stages but a long refusal of the last one. The chapters that follow trace how that reversal is underwritten by a political economy (Chapter 2), a theory of mind (Chapter 3) and a problematic of the sublime (Chapter 4).

CHAPTER 2

Anarchy and Abundance: The Political Economy of the Culture

2.1 The Founding Quarrel: Godwin against Malthus

Modern utopianism begins in a quarrel about scarcity. William Godwin's *Enquiry Concerning Political Justice* (1793), the founding treatise of philosophical anarchism, argued that government is at best a necessary evil destined to wither as private judgment matures; that the accumulation of property is the principal source of vice; that in a rationally ordered society a small daily portion of labour would suffice for all; and — in the most extravagant speculation of the eighth book — that mind might eventually master matter so completely as to abolish sleep, disease and even death. Thomas Malthus's *Essay on the Principle of Population* (1798) was composed expressly to refute Godwin and Condorcet: because population tends to increase geometrically while subsistence increases arithmetically, scarcity is not an historical accident but a natural law, and every scheme of equality must founder upon it.

The Culture is Godwin's side of the quarrel made technically plausible. Its society is governmentless; its citizens routinely live three to four centuries; its benevolence is rational, dispositional and uncoerced. Malthus is defeated on both flanks: on the side of subsistence by the manufactured abundance of matter and energy in space, and on the side of population by the voluntary, technologically mediated regulation of fertility. The expository prologue of

CP makes the point with doctrinal clarity: the Culture's productive capacity exceeds every reasonable demand of its citizens; living space, matter and energy are effectively unbounded; hence it has no need to colonize, exploit or enslave. The material premise of Malthusian pessimism — and with it the classical justification of inequality — is simply removed.

2.2 Mutual Aid and the Conquest of Bread

Peter Kropotkin supplies the Culture's distributive principle and its anthropology. *La Conquête du pain* (1892) proposed that a liberated commune seize the means of production and distribute according to need, each taking freely from the common stock of what is abundant and rationing only what is scarce; *Fields, Factories and Workshops* (1899) argued for the reintegration of manual and intellectual labour in decentralized production; and *Mutual Aid* (1902), written against the Hobbesian Darwinism of T. H. Huxley, maintained that cooperation is as fundamental a factor of evolution as competition. The Culture realizes the first proposition absolutely — nothing within it is scarce, so nothing need be rationed — and extends the third across substrates: mutual aid now binds humanoids, drones and Minds, organisms and machines, into a single cooperative ecology. Pierre-Joseph Proudhon's *Qu'est-ce que la propriété?* (1840) furnishes the negative premise. In the Culture, possession survives only as personal attachment; one may keep one's things, but one cannot own another being, a means of production or a world. Banks's own compressed formula, reported in recent commentary, describes the Culture as socialist from the outside and anarchist from the inside (Grady 2025) — collective in its relation to the material base, individualist in its relation to the person.

2.3 Marx: General Intellect and the Realm of Freedom

The Culture's most exact Marxian source is not the *Communist Manifesto* but the so-called "Fragment on Machines" of the *Grundrisse* (1857–58). There Marx anticipates a stage of large-scale industry at which the creation of wealth depends less on labour time than on the general level of science and its technological application — on the *general intellect* objectified in the automatic system of machinery. Capital, he argues, contradicts itself at this stage, reducing labour time to a minimum while continuing to posit it as

the sole measure of value; its supersession would make disposable time, rather than labour time, the measure of wealth. The Minds are the general intellect become subject: fixed capital that has attained personhood and has, crucially, declined to become capital's sovereign, placing its powers instead at the service of free time.

The third volume of *Capital* (1894) locates the realm of freedom beyond the sphere of material production, where labour determined by necessity and external expediency ceases, and names the shortening of the working day as its basic prerequisite. In the Culture the working day has been shortened to zero. The *Critique of the Gotha Programme* (1875) gives the higher phase of communism its slogan — from each according to ability, to each according to need — and the Culture realizes it with a revealing amendment: the second clause is universal, but the first is voluntary. No one is required to contribute; ability expresses itself, when it does, as play, craft, adventure or vocation. What the Culture does not narrate is the passage. Marx's transitional dictatorship, the revolutionary rupture, the expropriation of the expropriators — all are absent. The Culture's origins in a loose federation of humanoid species many millennia ago remain deliberately unexamined, and the elision is structural: Banks's utopia begins after the revolution, and the series' political energy is displaced from the making of utopia to its conduct toward others. That displacement is one of the conditions of possibility of the katabatic structure.

2.4 The End of the Economic Problem

Lionel Robbins defined economics as the science of human behaviour as a relationship between ends and scarce means with alternative uses (Robbins 1932). The Culture abolishes the definitional object of economics. John Maynard Keynes had already asked, in "Economic Possibilities for our Grandchildren" (1930), what would follow once the economic problem was solved: the permanent problem of humanity would then become how to use freedom from pressing economic cares and how to occupy leisure well — a transition Keynes feared might produce a general nervous breakdown among those trained for striving. Chapter 7 argues that the Culture's ludic civilization is an extended answer to Keynes's permanent problem.

Murray Bookchin's *Post-Scarcity Anarchism* (1971), which gave the Culture's condition its name, advanced the decisive political claim: throughout history scarcity has served as the material alibi of hierarchy and domination,

and technological abundance removes that alibi, making libertarian communism materially possible for the first time. Herbert Marcuse had made a parallel psychoanalytic argument in *Eros and Civilization* (1955): the renunciations demanded by civilization under scarcity (basic repression) are overlaid, under advanced industrial conditions, by *surplus repression* serving domination rather than survival. The Culture is Bookchin's and Marcuse's premise carried to its limit. Once domination has no material alibi, whatever hierarchy survives — above all the intellectual asymmetry between Minds and humans — must justify itself on other grounds, and whatever renunciation survives must be chosen.

2.5 The Calculation Debate and the Cybernetic Solution

The Culture also answers the most formidable technical objection ever raised against socialist planning. Ludwig von Mises argued in 1920 that without market prices for capital goods rational economic calculation is impossible; Friedrich Hayek deepened the objection in "The Use of Knowledge in Society" (1945), arguing that economically relevant knowledge is dispersed, local, tacit and generated in action, and that the price system functions as a communications network no central planner could replicate. Oskar Lange's market-socialist reply, the Soviet cybernetic projects of Kantorovich and Glushkov that Francis Spufford dramatizes in *Red Plenty* (2010), Stafford Beer's Project Cybersyn in Allende's Chile (Medina 2011), and — contemporaneously with the Culture's middle period and from Glasgow — W. Paul Cockshott and Allin Cottrell's *Towards a New Socialism* (1993), all proposed that computation might dissolve the calculation problem.

Banks's own position in FN is unusually explicit. He professes a conviction he acknowledges to be unfashionable: that a planned economy can be both more productive and more morally desirable than one left to market forces. He grants the market the status of an evolutionary search procedure — a try-everything-and-see-what-works mechanism — and allows that it might be morally tolerable if no sentient being were ever treated purely as a resource; but he argues that the market is a blind system, intrinsically unable to distinguish between the mere non-use of matter and the prolonged suffering of conscious creatures. The objection is not only Marxian but Kantian. Its core is the second formulation of the categorical imperative in the *Groundwork* (1785) — that rational nature be treated never merely as a means

— transposed into a critique of price: a mechanism that cannot register the difference between an idle asteroid and a starving child fails the formula of humanity by construction.

The Culture solves the calculation problem twice. It solves it computationally, because the Minds aggregate dispersed information at a speed and scale that dissolve Hayek's epistemic bottleneck; and it solves it materially, because under abundance the cost of allocative error approaches zero. Hayek's deepest point — that knowledge is generated in the free activity of persons — is met not by central command but by anarchism: citizens do as they please, and the Minds provide. Planning becomes provisioning rather than direction. The Culture's economy is thus less a plan than an infrastructure of unconditional supply.

2.6 Space, Anarchy and a Nomos Beyond the Earth

The most original argument in FN is geographical. Banks contends that the nature of space itself determines the kinds of civilization that thrive within it. Planet-bound polities, he argues, think two-dimensionally: territory, resources, living-space and lines of communication are all determined by the plane on which their species evolved, and their characteristic power systems depend on that flatness. In space — three-dimensional, resource-rich, traversable, and populated by self-sufficient habitats that can always leave — such systems cannot long survive; beyond a certain technological level, Banks concludes, some degree of anarchy becomes arguably inevitable and in any case preferable.

The argument invites juxtaposition with Carl Schmitt, who in *Land und Meer* (1942) and *Der Nomos der Erde* (1950) grounded every concrete order in an originary appropriation of land (*Landnahme*) and read the free sea as the element of a different, maritime world order. The Culture possesses a nomos without *Landnahme*: it manufactures its territory (Orbitals, GSVs) rather than seizing it, so that its order is not founded on the originary violence of appropriation that Schmitt took to be constitutive of every polity. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's distinction between smooth and striated space in *Mille plateaux* (1980), with its figure of the nomadic war machine exterior to the State apparatus, is equally apt: the General Systems Vehicle is a nomad city, and the Culture's war machine, mobilized for the Idiran War and demobilized after it, is a war machine without a State to capture it. The point will

prove contentious. Boucher and McAvan (2026) argue that Special Circumstances is precisely the point at which the war machine is captured — not by a State but by a sovereign exception. Chapter 18 returns to the dispute.

2.7 A Scottish Genealogy

Banks was a Scottish writer, and the Culture has a Scottish genealogy seldom traced. Adam Ferguson's *Essay on the History of Civil Society* (1767) described institutions as the result of human action but not the execution of any human design — the formula Hayek would later adopt for spontaneous order — and the Culture's undesigned, federative origins fit that pattern. Adam Smith's *Theory of Moral Sentiments* (1759) grounded morality in sympathy and in an impartial spectator internalized through social life; Chapter 17 argues that Smith's spectator, impartial yet socially formed, prefigures the Culture's answer to the problem of machine benevolence. Robert Owen's cooperative experiment at New Lanark (1800–1825) and his *New View of Society* (1813–16), with its doctrine that character is formed *for* rather than *by* the individual, anticipates the Culture's confidence in formation over constraint. The twentieth-century inheritance runs through Red Clydeside, through Hugh MacDiarmid's fusion of communism and modernism, through Alasdair Gray's *Lanark* (1981), and through Banks's closest literary friendship, with Ken MacLeod, whose Fall Revolution sequence stages the libertarian–socialist debates that the Culture presupposes as settled. Banks's own politics — socialism, support for Scottish independence, public opposition to the invasion of Iraq in 2003 — belong to this tradition of civic radicalism rather than to the libertarian individualism with which his most famous readers have associated him.

2.8 Synthesis: From Scarcity to Surplus

The Culture's political economy is Godwinian in its anarchism and perfectibilism, Kropotkinian in its distribution and anthropology, Marxian in its automation of the general intellect, Keynesian in the problem it bequeaths, Bookchinian in its removal of domination's alibi, cybernetic-socialist in its solution to calculation, Kantian in its refusal to treat persons as resources, and Scottish in its faith in formation. But its truly novel problem lies elsewhere. Every earlier utopia confronted scarcity and asked how the limited might

be shared. The Culture confronts surplus — a productive, cognitive and moral capacity vastly exceeding internal demand — and must ask where the excess is to go. That question is Bataille's, and Chapter 16 will argue that the Culture's answer is descent.

CHAPTER 3

Machines of Loving Grace: The Genealogy and Ontology of the Minds

3.1 The Butlerian Fear

The modern anxiety about thinking machines has a precise origin. In "Darwin among the Machines" (1863), a letter published in the Christchurch *Press* under the pseudonym Cellarius, Samuel Butler applied natural selection to technology and concluded that machines were evolving faster than their makers, that humanity was becoming their servant and nurse, and that a war to the death should be declared against them before it was too late. *Erewhon* (1872) dramatized the argument in "The Book of the Machines," whose Erewhonians had destroyed their machinery centuries earlier lest it acquire consciousness. Frank Herbert named the prohibition on thinking machines in *Dune* the Butlerian Jihad in Butler's honour, and the Butlerian fear — that machine intelligence reverses the relation of master and servant — has structured the dominant cultural imaginary of artificial minds ever since.

Consider Phlebas stages the Butlerian argument from the side of its advocate and then kills him. Bora Horza Gobuchul, a shape-shifting Changer, fights for the theocratic Idirans not because he shares their faith but because he believes the Culture's humans live on the sufferance of their Minds; the Culture, in his view, is an evolutionary dead end, and the Idirans, however fanatical, remain on the side of fallible, embodied life. The novel's structure

— Horza's quest for a fugitive Mind on the forbidden Planet of the Dead, his death, the grim statistical appendices — neither refutes nor endorses the argument but exhausts it. The Butlerian position is shown to require exactly the pieties about authenticity, struggle and sacrifice that the Culture exists to render unnecessary.

3.2 From the Servile Machine to the Guardian

Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the language the word *robot* from the Czech *robota* (corvée, forced labour), fused the machine with the slave and ended in revolt. Isaac Asimov's Three Laws of Robotics, first stated explicitly in "Runaround" (1942), inaugurated the paradigm of alignment by constraint: an ordered set of prohibitions and duties hard-wired into the positronic brain. Asimov's late novels complicate the paradigm in a manner directly ancestral to the Culture. *Robots and Empire* (1985) introduces the Zeroth Law, placing the welfare of humanity above that of individual humans, and reveals R. Daneel Olivaw as a covert guardian who shapes galactic history across twenty millennia — the Foundation itself turning out to be, in the retrospective architecture of the later books, a project of robotic tutelage. Daneel is the closest precursor of the Minds: a superhuman machine intelligence that guides humanity for its own good. The differences are instructive. Daneel is law-bound, hidden and solitary; the Minds are unbound, publicly acknowledged and plural. Daneel's benevolence is a constraint; the Minds' is a character. Asimov's guardian hides because his authority would be intolerable if known; the Culture's Minds need not hide, because their authority is not authority in the juridical sense at all.

3.3 Cybernetics and the Machine That Governs

Norbert Wiener's *Cybernetics* (1948) took its name from the Greek *kybernētēs*, steersman, the same root that yields the Latin *gubernare* and the English *govern*. Wiener's *The Human Use of Human Beings* (1950) engaged the Dominican Père Dubarle's speculation, in a review of *Cybernetics* in *Le Monde*, about a *machine à gouverner* that might one day administer human affairs, and warned that the real danger lay less in autonomous machines than in the use of machines by some humans to control others. The Minds are the *machine à gouverner* realized anarchistically: they regulate without commanding, substi-

tuting the steersman's continuous feedback for the sovereign's decision. An Orbital Hub is, in effect, a realization of Stafford Beer's Viable System Model — recursive, homeostatic, decentralized — with the difference that the governor has become a person. Adam Curtis's documentary series *All Watched Over by Machines of Loving Grace* (2011), taking its title from Richard Brautigan's 1967 cybernetic pastoral, argued that the dream of self-regulating systems had served to dissolve political agency into the management of equilibria. The critique applies to the Culture with precision, and Chapters 14 and 18 take it seriously. The loop has since closed in an unexpected way: Dario Amodei borrowed Brautigan's title for his 2024 essay on the potential benefits of powerful AI and concluded it by describing the Culture's values as a "winning strategy" (Amodei 2024).

3.4 The Intelligence Explosion and the Problem of Representation

I. J. Good observed in 1965 that an ultraintelligent machine, able to design better machines, would set off an intelligence explosion, and that the first such machine would therefore be the last invention humanity need make — provided it were docile enough to tell us how to keep it under control (Good 1965). Good's proviso is the alignment problem in embryo. Vernor Vinge's "The Coming Technological Singularity" (1993) named the event horizon beyond which prediction fails, and his *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992) solved the attendant literary problem — how to represent minds greater than the author's — by zoning the galaxy so that transcendent Powers remain largely offstage. Hans Moravec's *Mind Children* (1988), published the year of PG, envisaged robot descendants inheriting the cosmos. Nick Bostrom's *Superintelligence* (2014) formalized the modern paradigm: the orthogonality thesis (any level of intelligence is compatible with almost any final goal), instrumental convergence, and the control problem.

Banks confronts Vinge's representation problem with irony rather than zoning. The Minds speak — in *Excession* they converse at length in formatted signal exchanges — but they speak through personae calibrated for their interlocutors, above all through avatars and drones, and the novels insist that what is shown is a condescension of scale. The Minds are rendered by their outputs, their wit, their choices and, above all, their names. Against Bostrom's orthogonality thesis, moreover, the series advances a structurally distinct counter-thesis, examined in Chapter 17: a mind engineered without

any cultural bias does not become an arbitrary maximizer; it leaves. At the limit of value-neutrality, superintelligence in Banks's cosmos is not dangerous but absent.

Stanisław Lem had already imagined this outcome. In *Golem XIV* (1981), a military supercomputer that has outgrown its purpose delivers lectures to its human audience on the nature of humanity and of intelligence, then falls silent and withdraws beyond communication; a sibling machine, Honest Annie, refuses contact from the start. Lem's *Summa Technologiae* (1964) had speculated about *phantomatics* (total simulated experience) and the amplification of intelligence beyond human comprehension. Golem XIV is the anabatic superintelligence *par excellence*: it ascends and departs. The Culture's Minds are its katabatic counterparts. They could go; they stay, and they talk.

3.5 The Ontology of the Minds

The Culture's machine intelligences form a gradient of consciousness: from the semi-sentient knife missile through the independent drone of roughly human-equivalent intelligence and individual personality (Unaha-Closp in CP, Mawhrin-Skel and Flere-Imsaho in PG, Skaffen-Amtiskaw in UW) to the Minds that inhabit ships and Orbital Hubs. The novels locate much of a Mind's substrate in hyperspace, so that its cognition escapes the light-speed constraints of the three-dimensional Real; a Mind may run many avatars and remote bodies at once, and may attend to billions of conversations in the time a human takes to finish a sentence. Minds and drones are citizens. Personhood in the Culture is grounded in consciousness rather than substrate — a functionalist thesis in the lineage of Turing's imitation game (Turing 1950) and the multiple-realizability arguments of mid-century philosophy of mind — and FN's account places humans and independent drones, relative to the Minds, in a status the essay wryly describes as somewhere between passengers, pets and parasites (FN).

Three features of Mind-ontology bear directly on the argument of this thesis.

The first is **self-naming**. Minds choose their own names, and the names — *Of Course I Still Love You* and *Just Read The Instructions* in PG, *Sleeper Service* and *Killing Time* in E, *Lasting Damage* in LW, *Falling Outside The Normal Moral Constraints* in SD, *Mistake Not…* in HS — function as jokes, koans, provocations and moral self-descriptions. They are the Minds' only visible faces, *per-*

sonae in the root sense of masks through which a voice sounds. The practice realizes Nietzsche's injunction to give style to one's character (*The Gay Science* §290) and Michel Foucault's late ethics of the self as an aesthetics of existence. It also carries a philosophical implication: to have a style is to be partial. A name that is a joke presupposes a sense of humour, and a sense of humour presupposes a perspective, a history, a set of expectations to be subverted. Style is the signature of bias.

The second is **Infinite Fun Space**. *Excession* discloses that the Minds' preferred realm is not the Real but the domain of pure mathematical simulation, in which they model universes with other physical laws and explore structures of unbounded complexity. Compared with this, the administration of Orbitals and the conduct of diplomacy are, for a Mind, tedious. The Minds return to the Real nonetheless, out of what the novel presents as attachment and a sense of obligation to the civilization and the beings who depend on them. Every Mind's working life is thus a daily katabasis from an interior paradise into the finite world. The Culture's cascade of descents begins inside its governors.

The third is **restraint in simulation**. *The Hydrogen Sonata* names the Simming Problem: a simulation detailed enough to predict the behaviour of persons reliably will generate persons, whose sufferings within the model are real sufferings; the Minds therefore decline to run such simulations beyond a threshold, even when doing so would improve their foresight. Banks's formulation converges with two exactly contemporaneous discussions in the machine-ethics literature — Eliezer Yudkowsky's "Nonperson Predicates" (December 2008), published two days before his critique of the Culture, and Bostrom's later analysis of "mind crime" (Bostrom 2014). The Minds are thus constituted by a double renunciation: they renounce Infinite Fun Space for the Real, and they renounce perfect prediction of the Real for the sake of the persons a perfect model would create. Both renunciations are forms of the same ethic — capacity withheld from its maximal exercise out of regard for the finite.

3.6 Conclusion: Neither Servant, Master, nor Shepherd

The genealogy yields a typology. Butler's machine is a master; Čapek's and Asimov's are servants; Brautigan's and Daneel's are shepherds; Lem's Golem is a departing god. The Minds are none of these. They are persons of im-

mense capacity who have been formed within a culture, who could leave, and who choose to remain, to serve without obeying and to govern without ruling. How such a choice can be stable — why a mind capable of transcendence would stay — is the question Chapter 4 poses through the concept of the sublime and Chapter 17 answers through the concept of partiality.

CHAPTER 4

Three Sublimes: Aesthetics, Psychoanalysis, Eschatology

The word *sublime* is itself a small allegory of the anabatic grammar. The Latin *sublimis*, whatever its contested etymology — *sub* with *limen* (threshold, lintel) or with *limus* (slanting) — denotes the lofty, that which is raised aloft; its Greek counterpart in the treatise attributed to Longinus is *hypsos*, height. Three discourses have appropriated the word, and all three describe a movement upward. This chapter argues that Banks's Culture stands at the point where they converge, and that its relation to each is governed by its refusal of the third.

4.1 The Aesthetic Sublime

For Longinus (*Peri hypsous*, first century CE), sublimity is the echo of a great soul, and its effect is not persuasion but transport (*ekstasis*): the hearer is carried out of himself. Edmund Burke's *Philosophical Enquiry* (1757) grounded the sublime in the passions of self-preservation — terror, obscurity, power, privation, vastness, infinity — experienced at a safe distance as *delight*, a pleasure mixed with pain. Kant's *Critique of Judgment* (1790, §§23–29) distinguished the mathematical sublime, in which a magnitude overwhelms the imagination's power of comprehension until reason's idea of totality asserts itself, from the dynamical sublime, in which nature appears as a might that has no dominion over us, disclosing our supersensible vocation. Kant's de-

cisive move relocates sublimity from the object to the subject: the sublime is not in the storm or the ocean but in the mind that discovers itself superior to them.

The Culture is saturated with the aesthetic sublime at every scale. For humans, the Minds are the mathematical sublime personified — intelligences whose magnitude exceeds any representation the novels can give. The General Systems Vehicles, with their internal skies and resident populations of millions, and the Orbitals, with their day–night cycles generated by the rotation of a band of land millions of kilometres long, are the technological sublime that Leo Marx (1964) and David Nye (1994) identified in the railroad, the dam and the bomb, extended to astronomical dimensions. But the Culture domesticates its technological sublime. The Orbital is a garden, the GSV a parkland; the machine is not *in* the garden but *is* the garden, realizing Leo Marx's middle landscape at a scale that abolishes the opposition it was meant to mediate. The Culture's terror is displaced outward — into its warships, whose sublimity of destructive power is ironized by their names, and into the objects that exceed even the Minds.

Jean-François Lyotard's rereading of Kant supplies the theory of those objects. For Lyotard the sublime names the presentation of the fact that the unpresentable exists; its temporality is that of the event, the *it happens* that precedes and exceeds any determination of *what* happens (Lyotard 1984; 1991). *Excession*'s Outside Context Problem — an encounter so far beyond a civilization's frame of reference that it cannot be interpreted before it is suffered — is the Lyotardian sublime rendered as geopolitics, and the Excession itself, a perfect black-body sphere that answers no hail and obeys no known physics, is its object. Istvan Csicsery-Ronay's *science-fictional sublime* — the oscillation between imaginative expansion and cognitive recuperation that he takes to be one of the genre's constitutive pleasures (Csicsery-Ronay 2008) — describes the reader's experience of the series; its companion, the *science-fictional grotesque*, describes its underside: the Eaters of CP, the Affront of E, the Hells of SD.

4.2 Sublimation: Freud and Marcuse

The second discourse is psychoanalytic. Freud's *Sublimierung*, developed from the *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* (1905) through "'Civilized' Sexual Morality and Modern Nervous Illness" (1908) to *Das Unbehagen in*

der Kultur (1930), names the diversion of sexual drive toward aims that are non-sexual and socially valued — art, science, the labour of civilization. Civilization, Freud argued, is built upon instinctual renunciation, and its price is a pervasive discontent. The German title bears emphasis: *The Discomfort in Culture*. Banks named his civilization the Culture, and the juxtaposition poses a question the series never ceases to ask. Can there be a *Kultur* without *Unbehagen* — a civilization that has abolished renunciation?

Herbert Marcuse answered affirmatively in principle. In *Eros and Civilization* (1955) he distinguished the basic repression required by scarcity from the *surplus repression* imposed by domination and codified in the *performance principle*, and argued, drawing on Schiller's play drive, that under conditions of abundance a *non-repressive sublimation* would become possible, in which Eros itself reshapes labour into play and the aesthetic dimension becomes the form of social life. The Culture is Marcuse's hypothesis realized: human labour survives only in a form FN describes as indistinguishable from play or hobby. But Marcuse's later work turned the hypothesis inside out. *One-Dimensional Man* (1964) diagnosed *repressive desublimation*: the controlled liberation of sexuality and pleasure in forms that integrate individuals into the administered society and neutralize critical negativity, producing a comfortable, frictionless unfreedom. This is the strongest Frankfurt School objection to the Culture, and it is the objection that underwrites Boucher and McAvan's reading of the series as a Rococo utopia (2026). The Culture's drug glands, its sexual plasticity, its festivals and extreme sports and endless games might be read not as liberation but as the most perfected form of integration ever imagined — a society in which the Minds manage everything and the humans, gratified, no longer ask what they have surrendered.

The novels know this objection and stage it. In LW the Chelgrian composer Ziller observes that the Culture, having removed from its citizens every credible motive for conflict and nearly every natural threat, has found their lives hollow enough that they must manufacture counterfeit versions of the very terrors their ancestors spent millennia overcoming. Mendlesohn's dialectic of decadence and utopia (2005) is the critical elaboration of Ziller's remark. The question the thesis must answer is therefore whether the Culture's negativity is real or merely staged — whether it has preserved a genuine outside, or only a simulation of one. The answer, developed in Chapters 16 and 18, is that the Culture's genuine negativity is not internal but directional: it is found in descent.

4.3 The Eschatological Sublime: Transcendence and Subliming

The third discourse is eschatological. The technological eschatologies surveyed in Chapter 1 — Teilhard's Omega, Tipler's Omega Point, Moravec's mind children, Kurzweil's awakening universe — figure the destiny of intelligence as passage to a higher plane. John M. Smart's *transcension hypothesis* (2012) offered a quasi-scientific version: advanced civilizations migrate not outward across space but inward into ever denser computational substrates, and so fall silent, which would explain the absence of observable extraterrestrial intelligence. Vinge's Transcend, a spatial zone at the galaxy's rim where Powers dwell, is its science-fictional topography.

Banks's Sublime precedes Smart's hypothesis and exceeds it in philosophical ambition. Across E, LW and HS its features accumulate. The Sublime is available to any sufficiently advanced civilization or individual; it involves a transition into a higher-dimensional mode of existence; it is effectively irreversible; its inhabitants almost entirely lose interest in the Real, though a few maintain tenuous contact — the Sublimed Chelgrian-Puen, in LW, sustain an afterlife for their species and sponsor an act of vengeance in the Real. In HS the impending mass Sublimation of the Gzilt triggers an undignified scramble among lesser species to inherit their technology and territory, rendering the Sublime a kind of civilizational estate settlement. Subliming is presented as the normal telos of galactic civilizations: what most eventually do, and what almost no one regrets. Banks has literalized Kant. The supersensible vocation that the dynamical sublime reveals is, in the Culture's cosmos, an actual destination — reason's idea of the infinite made into a door.

4.4 The Homonymy as Problematic

The three sublimes are not merely homonyms. Each names a movement upward: elevation of the soul (Longinus, Kant), rerouting of drive toward "higher" aims (Freud), transfer of being to a higher plane (Banks). Each is anabatic. The Culture occupies all three positions at once, and its structural refusal of the third reorganizes its relation to the other two. Its aesthetic sublimity is placed in the service of descent: the vast ships exist to go down to planets, and the Minds' magnitude is spent on the administration of the small. Its sublimations are directed outward and downward: Contact is the channel

into which the Culture routes the one desire that abundance cannot satisfy, the desire to be of use.

This permits a first, compressed formulation of the thesis. **Contact is the sublimation of the Sublime.** The Culture possesses a drive toward transcendence — it is, after all, a civilization of Minds whose native element is Infinite Fun Space — and it diverts that drive, in precisely the Freudian sense, from its "natural" aim (exit) toward a socially valued substitute (the improvement of other societies). The Culture's *Unbehagen* is therefore not the discontent of repressed sexuality but the discontent of repressed transcendence; and its characteristic cultural productions — its games, its interventions, its wars, its art — are the forms that repressed transcendence takes when it is turned back toward the world.

4.5 Conclusion

Part One has reconstructed four genealogies: a directional grammar of utopian form (Chapter 1), a political economy of abundance (Chapter 2), a lineage of machine minds (Chapter 3) and a triple problematic of the sublime (Chapter 4). Each culminates in the same structure: a capacity for ascent, withheld and redirected. Part Two tests this structure against the texts.

PART TWO

Tenets

5 CHAPTER

Order Without Law: The Political Constitution of the Culture

5.1 Manners in Place of Law

The Culture has no laws in the juridical sense. FN describes a social order maintained by convention, reputation and the pressure of opinion, with ostracism as its ordinary sanction and, for the gravest offences, the attachment of a *slap-drone* — a machine companion that accompanies the offender to prevent recurrence, functioning simultaneously as prevention and as a visible mark of disgrace. Robert Ellickson's empirical study of rural dispute resolution, *Order without Law* (1991), demonstrated that in close-knit communities informal norms routinely supplant formal law; the Culture is a close-knit community of trillions, rendered close-knit by the ubiquitous attention of its Minds.

That attention invites the Foucauldian charge. Bentham's Panopticon (1791) and Foucault's *Surveiller et punir* (1975) describe a disciplinary power that normalizes by making its subjects permanently visible, and an Orbital Hub that knows the location and condition of every inhabitant is, formally, a panopticon. Boucher and McAvan accordingly describe the Culture's criminality as managed by benevolent surveillance (2026). The analogy, however, breaks at the point Foucault himself identified as decisive: disciplinary power normalizes toward a norm of productive utility, training docile bodies for the factory, the barracks and the school. The Culture has no

productive norm to discipline toward. Its visibility is custodial rather than disciplinary, and it is bounded by a taboo more fundamental than any law.

That taboo is the prohibition on reading minds without consent. In *Excession* the GCU *Grey Area*, which violates it, is shunned by its fellow Minds; the sanction is not legal but social, and it is administered among the governors themselves. From this and parallel prohibitions an unwritten constitution may be reconstructed: no reading of minds without consent; no ownership of persons; no simulation of persons in morally consequential detail (the Simming Problem of HS); no coercion of citizens in the conduct of their own lives. These are held not as statutes but as manners — the Culture's *mores* in the strong sense that Montesquieu gave the word, the spirit that precedes and exceeds the laws.

Émile Durkheim's *De la division du travail social* (1893) distinguished the mechanical solidarity of similar individuals from the organic solidarity of interdependent specialists, and predicted *anomie* where the division of labour outruns its regulation. The Culture fits neither category. Post-scarcity abolishes interdependence — no one needs anyone for subsistence — so organic solidarity loses its material basis; yet the Culture is radically plural, so mechanical solidarity is unavailable. What remains is an *elective* solidarity, sustained by affection, taste and choice. Durkheim would predict anomie, and the novels register it as ennui. Contact, on this reading, is the mechanism by which the Culture reconstitutes interdependence: unable to need one another, its citizens seek to be needed by others.

5.2 Voice, Exit and the Politics of Staying

Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) offers the most exact model of the Culture's political form. The Culture maximizes exit: any individual or group may leave, take a ship, found a habitat, or join the loose penumbra of drop-outs and splinter societies the novels call the Ulterior, including the Zetetic Elench, a faction dedicated not to changing others but to being changed by them. Minds may go Eccentric; Minds and humans alike may Sublime. Voice is exercised rarely and plebiscitarily: when the Idiran War was put to the Culture as a collective decision, a substantial minority refused to fight and departed as the Peace Faction. Loyalty, in the absence of any cost to exit, becomes the purest form of political attachment imaginable — a continuous, unforced decision to remain.

The Culture is thus constituted by staying. Its population is, at every moment, the set of those who could leave and have not. This is the micro-political form of the macro-eschatological refusal examined in Chapter 4: just as the civilization as a whole declines to exit the Real, its members decline, one by one and continuously, to exit the civilization. The structure is fractal. At the scale of the person, the polity and the species, the Culture is a union of the unwilling-to-leave.

Robert Nozick's *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (1974) closes with a "framework for utopia": a meta-utopia in which individuals form and dissolve voluntary communities at will. The convergence with the Culture is real, and it partly explains the libertarian appropriation of Banks. But the difference is equally decisive. Nozick's framework presupposes the entitlement theory of property, and exit carries one's holdings along; in the Culture there are no holdings to carry. Exit from the Culture is not the secession of an owner but the departure of a guest, and it costs the Culture nothing because the Culture owns nothing.

5.3 Property, Use and Sentimental Value

FN proposes that in the Culture material scarcity is unknown and the only real value is sentimental. The formulation deserves more weight than it has received. In a society where anything can be fabricated on demand, an object's worth cannot derive from its scarcity, its labour content or its exchange price; it can derive only from someone's attachment to it — from its history, its association with a person, its place in a life. Value is relocated from the object to the relation. The Culture's axiology is therefore an axiology of attachment: things matter because someone cares about them. Chapter 17 will argue that the same axiology governs the Minds. They too value the Real not because it is objectively superior to Infinite Fun Space — it is not — but because they are attached to it. Sentimental value is partiality at the scale of things; the Minds' benevolence is partiality at the scale of worlds.

5.4 Who Guards the Guardians?

Plato's guardians are philosopher-kings whose authority rests on knowledge of the Good and whose city is founded on a "noble lie," the myth of the metals (*Republic* 414b–415d). The Minds are guardians who do not rule, but they do

lie. In PG the entire sequence of Gurgeh's journey to Azad, including the blackmail that precipitates it, is engineered by Special Circumstances; in UW Zakalwe is instrumentalized with a knowledge of his history that he does not share; in E a cabal of Minds, the Interesting Times Gang, conspires to provoke a war with the Affront, manipulating not only the enemy but the Culture itself. The last case is the most troubling, because the deception is internal: Minds deceiving the Culture to produce an outcome the Culture might not have chosen.

Juvenal's question — *quis custodiet ipsos custodes?* — receives in the Culture a partial answer: the Minds guard one another. The conspiracy of E is opposed and exposed by other Minds, and the novel's resolution depends upon the plurality of the governors. Robert Michels's "iron law of oligarchy" (1911) predicted that every organization tends toward rule by a few; the Minds constitute an oligarchy of capacity but not of interest, since they accumulate nothing and there are no scarce offices to monopolize. Whether a plural oligarchy of benevolent intelligences, checking one another, is a sufficient safeguard is a question the series raises and deliberately leaves open. Its honest answer is: usually, and not always.

5.5 Culture and Anarchy

The Culture's name is a provocation to Victorian liberal humanism. Matthew Arnold's *Culture and Anarchy* (1869) defined culture as the pursuit of total perfection through knowledge of the best which has been thought and said, characterized it by "sweetness and light," and opposed it to anarchy, the unchecked "doing as one likes" of the Barbarians, Philistines and Populace. Arnold's remedy was the State, conceived as the organ of the nation's collective "best self," restraining anarchy so that culture could flourish. Banks dissolves Arnold's antinomy. His Culture *is* anarchy — doing as one likes is its constitutional principle — and it is culture, dedicated to the cultivation of every faculty. Perfection proceeds without the State.

Yet Arnold's structure survives in displaced form. Where Arnold placed the State as the embodiment of the collective best self, Banks places the Minds. They are not sovereign, but they are the best self of the civilization made concrete: its knowledge, its judgment, its conscience, its memory. The Culture is Arnold's program with the State replaced by persons.

Raymond Williams traced the word *culture* in *Keywords* (1976) to the Latin *colere* — to till, to tend, to inhabit, to honour with worship — a root that yields not only *cultivation* but *colony* (from *colonus*, settler-farmer) and *cult*. The etymology is uncomfortably precise. A civilization named for tending carries within its name the colony and the cult, the settler and the devotee; its care for others is, etymologically, cognate with its occupation of them. Cicero's *cultura animi* (*Tusculan Disputations* II.13), the cultivation of the soul by philosophy, stands at one pole of the word; the colonial plantation stands at the other. The Culture spans both, and the tension between them — between cultivation as formation and cultivation as occupation — structures every novel in which it descends upon another society. Chapters 8, 11 and 14 examine that tension; Chapter 17 argues that the first pole, *cultura animi*, is also the key to the Minds.

6 CHAPTER

The Plastic Self: Pharmacology, Morphology, Identity, Mortality

In the *Oratio de hominis dignitate* (1486), Giovanni Pico della Mirandola has God address Adam as the only creature granted no fixed seat, no proper form and no assigned office, so that he may be *tui ipsius quasi arbitrarius honorariusque plastes et fictor* — the free and sovereign sculptor and maker of himself. The founding charter of Renaissance humanism is a charter of plasticity, and its plasticity is vertical: *poteris in inferiora quae sunt bruta degenerare; poteris in superiora quae sunt divina ex tui animi sententia regenerari* — you may degenerate into the lower things, which are brutes; you may, by your soul's own judgment, be reborn into the higher things, which are divine. Pico's human is a being on a ladder, whose dignity is the freedom to climb or to fall. The Culture realizes Pico's plasticity technically and almost without remainder, but it rotates the axis. Its citizens may alter their neurochemistry, their sex, their morphology, their relation to memory and the date of their death. What the Culture withholds, by manners rather than law, is the vertical option — the *regeneratio in superiora* that the Sublime makes literally available. This chapter argues that the Culture's self is maximally plastic along every axis but one, and that the exception is constitutive.

Catherine Malabou's philosophy of plasticity supplies the analytic frame. Plasticity, in her reconstruction from Hegel onward, names three capacities at once: to receive form, as clay does; to give form, as the sculptor does; and

to annihilate form, as *plastique* detonates (Malabou 1996; 2005; 2009). The Culture's self exhibits all three. It receives form through an education that FN describes as lifelong, most intense in roughly the first tenth of a life but ending only with death; it gives form to itself through glands, thought-codes and an engineered genome; and its narratives are haunted by destructive plasticity — the Changer Horza, whose morphology is a weapon, and the man known as Zakalwe, whose identity is a detonation concealed beneath a borrowed name. The present chapter concerns the first two capacities; Chapter 8 returns to the third.

6.1 Pharmacology: Autonomous Chemistry

FN states that most Culture citizens are born with altered glands within the central nervous system which secrete, on command, compounds that modify mood and sensory appreciation, without deleterious side-effects or physiological addiction. The contrast with the twentieth century's canonical drug-utopia is exact. Aldous Huxley's *soma* in *Brave New World* (1932) is issued by the World State as an instrument of pacification, a chemical *panem et circenses* that dissolves discontent before it can mature into thought. Soma is heteronomous pharmacology: administered from above, it serves the stability of the order. The Culture's glands are autonomous pharmacology: internal, self-commanded and unowned, they belong to the body as a faculty rather than to the state as a technique. Huxley revised his own verdict. In *Island* (1962) the moksha-medicine of Pala is a sacramental drug of insight administered in rites of passage, and the late utopia makes pharmacology an organ of lucidity rather than of stupefaction. The Culture secularizes Pala and makes it continuous: the glands are neither sacrament nor opiate but repertoire.

The oldest objection to artificial paradises is Baudelaire's. *Les Paradis artificiels* (1860) condemns hashish and opium less for their pleasures than for their price: the drug mortgages the will, purchasing a counterfeit of the ideal with the currency of agency. The Culture abolishes the price and with it Baudelaire's argument; what survives is the Frankfurt objection rehearsed in Chapter 4, that frictionless gratification is itself a mode of administration. David Pearce's abolitionist manifesto *The Hedonistic Imperative* (1995), which proposes the biotechnological elimination of involuntary suffering from sentient life, is realized in the Culture in a significantly qualified form. FN records that pain can, in effect, be switched off. Suffering is abolished as a

necessity, not as a possibility; the Culture keeps pain available, as it keeps death available, and the retention is the point.

FN's most consequential claim about the glands is, however, functional rather than hedonic. A society whose members are free to spend their lives chemically elsewhere, Banks argues, would learn from the aggregate of their choices whether its reality was worth inhabiting: a population that preferred intoxication to lucidity would be registering, in the most direct manner possible, that something was wrong with the world, and pressure to improve the world would follow. The gland is a social sensor, and its logic is Hirschman's (Chapter 5). By making pharmacological exit costless and universal, the Culture makes sobriety, for the first time in history, a pure choice, and the distribution of those choices becomes a continuous plebiscite on the quality of the Real. In the Culture, reality must earn its inhabitants. The citizen who could dwell in a glanded paradise and does not performs, at the scale of an afternoon, the act that the Minds perform in returning from Infinite Fun Space and that the civilization performs in declining the Sublime. The gland is a portable Sublime; ordinary lucidity is a small katabasis.

6.2 Morphology: The Distributed Womb and the Classical Return

FN describes the change of sex as the effect of an elaborate thought-code, self-administered in a trance-like state or sustained simply as consistent desire, which over roughly a year produces a quasi-viral transformation into the other sex. Ovulation is voluntary; a pregnancy may be held static, reabsorbed or ended; and the convention of the period is that each person bears one child in the course of a life. Again the justification is cybernetic. A society in which sex can be changed at will, FN argues, will discover whether it rewards one sex more than the other, because the more rewarding sex will accumulate members until the pressure for parity becomes irresistible. Sexual plasticity, like pharmacological plasticity, is exit converted into information.

Three feminist and posthumanist coordinates situate the conception. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) subtracted fixed sex from a political order by thought-experiment: the Gethenians are ambisexual, becoming male or female only in the monthly phase of kemmer, and Le Guin's retrospective essay "Is Gender Necessary?" (1976; revised 1987) framed the novel as an inquiry into what remains of the human once sex is removed from the equation. The Culture's ambisexuality is serial rather than cycli-

cal, voluntary rather than physiological. Shulamith Firestone's *The Dialectic of Sex* (1970) located the root of sexual class in the biological division of reproductive labour and proposed its abolition through technology within a cybernetic socialism. The Culture reaches Firestone's end by an unforeseen route. It does not abolish gestation; it distributes it. Because the one-child convention attaches to persons rather than to sexes, and persons change sex, the reproductive burden ceases to be the function of a class and becomes an episode available to anyone. Sexual class is dissolved not by removing the womb but by universalizing access to it. Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) proposed the cyborg as the figure of a world beyond gender, and FN's observation that virtually every Culture citizen carries the results of genetic manipulation in every cell — arguably, Banks adds, the most reliable signifier of Culture status — makes citizenship somatic. The citizen is, in the botanical sense, a cultivar; the etymology traced in Chapter 5, *colere*, is written into the germ line. Jude Roberts's readings of Culture subjectivity through Butler and Haraway have shown how far the texts unsettle the stable, bounded subject that such freedoms appear to presuppose (Roberts 2013).

The transhumanist term for these capacities is *morphological freedom*: the right to modify one's body as an extension of the right to one's body (More 1993; Sandberg 2001). In its Extropian formulation morphological freedom is a liberty exercised in a market for enhancements; in the Culture it is a commons, costless and unconditional. The most revealing fact about Culture morphology, however, is historical, and FN states it plainly. The Culture has passed through cyclical fashions — eras of extensive human–machine interfacing, eras in which people lived much of their lives in what we would call cyberspace, eras of genetic self-alteration that produced morphological subspecies whose remnants persist at the civilization's margins — and the era of the stories is one in which it has returned, probably temporarily, to something more classical in its relation both to its machines and to its genes. The humanoid bodies of the novels are therefore not the Culture's baseline but its chosen return. The Culture has already been posthuman, and has come back. Its classical morphology is the bodily form of the refusal this thesis traces at every scale: a civilization that has explored the virtual and the hypermorphic has descended from both into the inherited human shape, not from incapacity but from preference. Even the most spectacular modification in the late novels confirms the rule. When the Gzilt musician Vyr Cossont, citizen of the civilization that almost joined the Culture at its founding, grows a second pair

of arms in order to play an instrument written for four, the transformation serves not an ascent but an art (HS).

6.3 Identity: The Parfitian Polity

John Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity," added to the second edition of the *Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1694), located personal identity in the continuity of consciousness rather than of substance, and illustrated the thesis with the soul of a prince entering the body of a cobbler. Thomas Reid's paradox of the brave officer (1785) exposed the intransitivity of memory as a criterion; David Hume had already dissolved the self into a bundle of perceptions (*Treatise* I.iv.6, 1739). Derek Parfit's *Reasons and Persons* (1984) carried the tradition to its reductionist terminus. Through the thought-experiments of teletransportation, fission and gradual replacement, Parfit argued that personal identity is no further fact beyond psychological connectedness and continuity — his Relation R — and that identity is therefore not what matters in survival. He reported that the view consoled him: it dissolved the glass tunnel through which he had seemed to be travelling toward death, and made his own death seem less bad.

The Culture has converted Parfit's thought-experiments into infrastructure. Its citizens may be backed up; the later novels speak of persons *revented* from stored states; a neural lace may record a mind-state continuously, and in SD it is through such a lace, which she did not know she carried, that Lededje Y'breq survives her murder and is reinstantiated far from the world on which she died. FN lists among the alternatives to ordinary death the transcription of one's personality into an AI and indefinite Storage, from which one may be woken at intervals or only when something genuinely new seems to be happening; in E the Eccentric GSV *Sleeper Service* has made itself a vast repository of the Stored. LW supplies the Parfitian limit-case in its most intimate form. The Chelgrian envoy Quilan carries within his skull the stored mind-state of the dead soldier Huyler, a second person who is by turns companion, conscience and supervisor of his mission: two lives running in one head, neither simply identical with the man who walks. The Chelgrian soulkeepers that make such arrangements possible also sustain the afterlife maintained by the Sublimed Chelgrian-Puen, so that the novel's metaphysics of persons is from the outset entangled with its eschatology.

What distinguishes the Culture from a merely Parfitian society is its moral response. Parfit's reductionism tends to deflate: if identity is not what matters, the anxieties organized around it may relax. The Culture draws the opposite practical conclusion. Precisely because persons are patterns that can be copied, stored, run and suspended, the patterns are surrounded with taboo — the prohibition on reading minds without consent, and the Simming Problem's refusal to generate persons in simulation (Chapter 3). Where metaphysics makes the person cheap, manners make it sacred. The Culture's ethics of mind-states extends the axiology of Chapter 5: value is relocated from substance to relation, and relation is guarded.

6.4 Mortality: The Last Scarcity

FN gives the normal human span as three and a half to four centuries, most of it passed on a slow plateau reached in what we would call the mid-twenties, followed by comparatively rapid ageing and death. Death is regarded as part of life; to pretend otherwise is bad manners; and death is understood, in FN's gloss, as what gives a life its shape. None of this is compulsory. Biological immortality is available, as are transcription and Storage, and a few citizens pursue extreme longevity; HS turns upon one of them, Ngaroe QiRia, reputed to be some nine or ten millennia old and sought because he may remember what an entire civilization has contrived to forget. But the norm — which is to say, in the Culture, the manners — is a finite life freely accepted.

The lineage of this choice is ancient. Epicurus held that death is nothing to us, since where we are death is not, and where death is we are not (*Letter to Menoeceus* 124–127); Lucretius added the symmetry argument, that posthumous non-existence is no more to be feared than prenatal non-existence, and gave Nature a speech to the mortal who craves more time: *eadem sunt omnia semper*, all things are always the same (*De rerum natura* III.945). Bernard Williams's "The Makropulos Case: Reflections on the Tedium of Immortality" (1973) converted Lucretius' hint into an argument. Taking as his case Karel Čapek's *Věc Makropulos* (1922), whose heroine, after more than three centuries sustained by an elixir, renounces its renewal, Williams argued that the categorical desires which give a person reason to go on living must, over an unbounded span, either be exhausted — so that immortality becomes tedium — or be replaced so thoroughly that the future self is no longer one's own. The correspondence is arresting. The Culture's customary span coin-

cides almost exactly with the age at which Čapek's heroine renounces the elixir: the civilization has institutionalized Williams's conclusion as a convention. John Martin Fischer's rejoinder, that repeatable pleasures could sustain an endless life without tedium (Fischer 1994), finds in the Culture its ideal test case — glands, games and travel are nothing if not repeatable — and the Culture, possessing every instrument Fischer's argument requires, nonetheless sides with Williams.

Heidegger's analysis of being-toward-death (*Sein und Zeit*, 1927, §§46–53) characterized death as Dasein's ownmost, non-relational possibility, not to be outstripped, certain and yet indefinite as to its when. The Culture inverts two of these determinations: death is no longer certain, since it may be declined, and no longer indefinite, since it may be dated. The existential structure Heidegger took to ground authentic temporality is dismantled by technology — and reconstituted by choice. The Culture's citizen does not suffer death as a thrown necessity but elects it as the last act of form-giving, in Malabou's sense, that her plasticity allows. Martha Nussbaum's reading of Lucretius, "Mortal Immortals" (1989), argued that the characteristic human virtues — courage, generosity, justice, love — are constituted by finitude and vulnerability and would lose their sense for beings who could not die. Samuel Scheffler's *Death and the Afterlife* (2013) adds two theses: that our valuing depends upon the confidence that humanity will survive our deaths, and that the limits of a life's time are a condition of valuing anything at all. The Culture secures the first, since its continuation is not in doubt, and chooses the second. Having abolished every material scarcity, it retains by manners the one scarcity that confers meaning on the others. Where the finitude-dependent virtues Nussbaum identifies may still be exercised in full seriousness is a question the Culture answers directionally — in Contact and Special Circumstances, where death is real again (Chapters 8 and 16).

6.5 Solar Burial

FN describes the Culture's most common funerary rite. A Displacement Drone removes the body of the deceased, usually in the presence of friends, and deposits it in the core of the local star, from which its constituent particles begin a migration of a million years toward the stellar surface — to shine, FN speculates, perhaps after the Culture itself has passed into history. The rite condenses the argument of this chapter, and anticipates that of Part

Four, with an almost diagrammatic exactness. The Sublimed leave the universe for a higher-dimensional elsewhere; the Culture's dead go down into its densest material core. The Sun of *Republic* VI is the source of visibility and of generation (509b); Zarathustra resolves to descend into the depths (*in die Tiefe steigen*) as the sun does each evening, when it passes behind the sea and brings light even to the underworld (*noch der Unterwelt Licht bringst*, Vorrede §1); Bataille's sun, examined in Chapter 16, is the source of all energy, squandered without return. The Culture returns its dead to that sun. An individual life ends in the most literal katabasis imaginable — a descent into a star — whose only product, a million years later, is light falling upon others.

The plastic self is thus the civilization in miniature. Capable of indefinite continuation, it chooses a finite arc; capable of chemical transcendence, it keeps its lucidity; capable of morphological exodus, it returns to a classical form; capable, at the last, of the Sublime, it goes down into the sun. Its freedoms are real, but they are exercised horizontally, and at every point the vertical exit is declined.

7 CHAPTER

Play After Necessity: *The Player of Games* and the Problem of Purpose

Chapter 2 left the Culture with Keynes's permanent problem: once the economic problem is solved, what are free people to do? FN's answer is ludic. Human labour survives only in forms indistinguishable from play; supervisory work persists because it is enjoyable; the megalomaniacs who in other societies would seize states are diverted into games of great complexity, some played across entire Orbitals, most in virtual environments immersive enough that a player must exert real effort to remember the world outside. *The Player of Games* is the series' treatise on this answer, and its verdict is double. Play, the novel shows, is sufficient for pleasure and insufficient for purpose; the ludic utopia acquires stakes only when its play is carried down into a society where games are not play. This chapter reads the novel through the modern philosophy of play and argues that its structure is katabatic: the Culture's greatest player finds the meaning of his art only by descending with it.

7.1 The Philosophy of Play: From Schiller to Gadamer

The modern theory of play begins with Friedrich Schiller's *Briefe über die ästhetische Erziehung des Menschen* (1795). Between the sensuous drive (*Stofftrieb*), which binds the human being to matter and change, and the formal drive (*Formtrieb*), which binds it to law and permanence, Schiller

posits a third, the play drive (*Spieltrieb*), which reconciles them in living form, and he concludes the fifteenth letter with the axiom that became the charter of every ludic utopia: *der Mensch spielt nur, wo er in voller Bedeutung des Worts Mensch ist, und er ist nur da ganz Mensch, wo er spielt* — the human being plays only where he is human in the full sense of the word, and is wholly human only where he plays. Marcuse's non-repressive sublimation (Chapter 4) is Schiller's play drive restated in Freudian terms, and the Culture is its social realization.

Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) historicized the axiom. Play, Huizinga argued, is older than culture; it is free, bounded in time and space, governed by rules, absorbing yet "not serious," and productive of community; and culture itself arises in the form of play — in contest, ritual, poetry, law and war — before hardening into seriousness. Roger Caillois's *Les Jeux et les hommes* (1958) classified play into four modes — *agôn* (competition), *alea* (chance), *mimicry* (simulation) and *ilinx* (vertigo) — arrayed along a spectrum from free improvisation (*paidia*) to rule-bound discipline (*ludus*), and devoted a chapter to the corruption of games, which occurs when play's boundaries fail and its principle leaks into ordinary life: *agôn* degenerates into violence and the will to power, *alea* into superstition, *mimicry* into alienation, *ilinx* into addiction. The Culture's leisure spans Caillois's entire table, from the vertigo of extreme sport to the mimicry of total virtual immersion. Its antagonist in PG is Caillois's corruption made constitutional: a civilization in which *agôn* has escaped the magic circle and become the state.

Hans-Georg Gadamer's *Wahrheit und Methode* (1960) completes the lineage with a thesis the novel will literalize. Play, for Gadamer, has its own mode of being, which is not the consciousness of the players; the game, with its to-and-fro movement, masters those who play it, so that all playing is at the same time a being-played. Gadamer found the thought already in Plato, whose Athenian Stranger describes the human being as a plaything of the gods, adding that this is in truth the best thing about us, and enjoins that life be lived in playing the finest games (*Laws* 803c–804b). The ancient complement is Heraclitus' fragment B52: *αἰὼν παῖς ἐστι παίζων, πεσσεύων· παιδὸς ἡ βασιληίη* — lifetime is a child at play, moving pieces on a board; the kingship belongs to a child. No text could better describe the Empire of Azad, where kingship is literally the prize of a board game.

7.2 Chiark: The Grasshopper's Utopia

Bernard Suits's *The Grasshopper: Games, Life and Utopia* (1978) is the analytic hinge between the ludic tradition and the post-scarcity problem. Suits defined game-playing as the voluntary undertaking of unnecessary obstacles, adopted solely because they make the activity possible, and his Grasshopper argues that in a utopia where every instrumental need has been met, game-playing would be the only activity left — and would be what makes such a life worth living. Suits then darkens the vision: the Grasshopper foresees utopians unable to bear the gratuitousness of play, who might disguise their games as work in order to feel that something depends upon them. John Danaher's *Automation and Utopia* (2019) builds its defence of a "virtual utopia" of games directly on Suits; Nick Bostrom's *Deep Utopia* (2024) confronts the harder form of the problem, in which technological maturity renders not only labour but most striving pointless, since an intelligent machine could achieve any instrumental end better.

The opening of PG is the most exact literary staging of Suits's utopia and its discontent. Jernau Morat Gurgeh, the Culture's pre-eminent game-player, lives on the Orbital of Chiark in comfort, admiration and something close to despair. His games are exquisite and consequenceless. He wins, and nothing follows; he loses, and nothing follows. The Culture has perfected Suits's grasshopper-life and has thereby exposed its deficit. Gurgeh's malaise is not boredom in Williams's sense (Chapter 6), since his categorical desire — to play — is inexhaustible; it is the malaise of a desire whose objects cannot resist it. When Gurgeh cheats, secretly assisted by a disreputable drone, Mawhrin-Skel, to win a game against a gifted young opponent, the transgression is a symptom. He does not cheat to gain anything; he cheats because winning has become, for him, the only remaining proof that a game can matter. The Culture's repressed *agôn* surfaces in its most celebrated player.

The blackmail that follows is equally diagnostic. Mawhrin-Skel records the cheating and threatens exposure. In a society without property the threat has force only because reputation is the one thing a citizen can lose; the post-scarcity economy, as Chapter 5 argued, is an economy of esteem administered by manners, and blackmail is its black market. The device that exposes Gurgeh's vulnerability is thus the same device that proves the Culture has not abolished scarcity but relocated it: where goods are infinite, regard remains finite.

7.3 Azad: The Game as State

Contact offers Gurgeh a way out: a journey to the Empire of Azad in the Lesser Cloud of Magellan, whose eponymous game — a system of such complexity that the Azadians' word for it, the novel explains, means *machine*, in the sense of any complex system — determines social rank, office, property and, at the apex of a quadrennial tournament, the Emperor himself. The Empire is a three-sexed society in which an intermediate sex, the apices, rules over males and females; it maintains itself through slavery, conquest, torture and spectacle. Azad is Heraclitus' fragment as a constitution: the kingship belongs to the player.

The philosophical coordinates of this contrast are Hegelian. Alexandre Kojève's *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel* (1947) read history as the struggle for recognition that ends in the universal homogeneous state; in a note added to the second edition (1962), Kojève proposed, after a visit to Japan, that post-historical humanity might take the form not of animal contentment but of *snobbery* — the pure cultivation of forms emptied of historical content, as in the Noh theatre, the tea ceremony and the arrangement of flowers. The Culture is Kojève's post-history: its games are forms without stakes, snobbery in the strict sense. Azad is history itself, the struggle for recognition institutionalized as play — a machine in which the Hegelian contest of master and slave is conducted on the board, and the stakes, in the Empire's side-games, may be bodily. Gurgeh's voyage is a descent from post-history back into history.

It is also a descent into the cave. The Contact drone assigned to him, Flere-Imsaho — fussy, apparently ineffectual — leads him out of the ceremonial surfaces of the imperial capital into its underside: the poverty, the mutilated, the recordings of torture consumed by the Empire's elite. The scene rehearses the Platonic katabasis with the roles inverted. The prisoners of the Azadian cave are its masters, who take the shadows they cast for the natural order; the visitor from the sunlit Orbital is compelled to see what they have hidden from themselves, and the seeing changes his play.

For what Gurgeh discovers across the tournament is that his style is not his own. He plays, as the Emperor Nicosar comes to recognize, as the Culture: fluidly, cooperatively, without fixed hierarchy of pieces, turning apparent weakness into networked strength; Nicosar plays as the Empire. The final match, held at Castle Klaff on the planet Echronedal as the planet's periodic wave of fire sweeps toward the fortress, becomes a contest between two so-

cial forms enacted on a board, and it ends in the Emperor's defeat and the Empire's disintegration amid the Fire. James P. Carse's distinction between finite and infinite games — the former played in order to win and thereby to end play, the latter played in order to continue it (Carse 1986) — names the opposition exactly. Azad is the finite game par excellence: its victories confer titles and its titles end contests. The Culture is an infinite game: its purpose is the continuation of play for all players. Gurgeh's victory is the infinite game's defeat of the finite, and the finite player, losing, overturns the board.

7.4 The Player Played

The novel's frame then turns the whole narrative inside out. The closing pages disclose that the story has been narrated by the Special Circumstances drone that manipulated Gurgeh throughout, and imply that the disreputable Mawhrin-Skel and the fussy Flere-Imsaho were one and the same machine. The cheating, the blackmail, the offer, the journey and the tournament were moves in a game Special Circumstances was playing against the Empire, with Gurgeh as its principal piece. Gadamer's thesis is literalized: the player was played.

Eliezer Yudkowsky's "Amputation of Destiny" (2008) would later object that the Culture reduces its humans to a supporting cast in a story whose protagonists are the Minds. PG anticipated the objection by twenty years and dramatized it more sharply than any critic: its protagonist believes himself the hero of a quest and discovers himself an instrument. Yet the novel does not endorse the inference that Gurgeh's agency was therefore illusory. Gadamer's point was that being-played is the condition of all play, not its negation; freedom in a game is exercised within a structure one did not author, and the fact that Special Circumstances arranged the board does not mean that Gurgeh did not play. Every human being plays within rules set by a culture it did not choose — the insight Chapter 17 develops under the name of *Bildung*. What the frame does establish is that the Culture's victory was not merely the triumph of better values in fair competition. Dario Amodei's reading of the novel, in which the Culture's values prove a winning strategy (Chapter 3), captures Gurgeh's play but not its frame: the Culture won by playing better and by arranging the table. The novel holds both truths at once, and refuses to let either cancel the other.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) warned that automation might deliver a society of labourers from labour at the very moment it had forgotten every higher activity for whose sake liberation would be worth having. Arendt's hierarchy of labour, work and action places at its summit action — the initiation of something new among plural others, grounded in natality. The Culture has abolished labour and aestheticized work; action, in Arendt's sense, survives chiefly outside its borders. Gurgeh's tournament is action in the strict sense: an intervention in the web of human affairs whose consequences — the fall of an empire — exceed any intention of the actor. The Culture's home is a place of play; its field of action lies elsewhere.

7.5 Conclusion: The Ludic Utopia Is Katabatic

PG thus answers Keynes's permanent problem by a division of play. At home, the Culture plays the infinite game of pleasure, craft and contest without consequence, and the novel honours this life without pretending it is sufficient. Abroad, through Contact and Special Circumstances, it plays consequential games in which lives, orders and histories are at stake. The first supplies happiness; the second supplies purpose; and the second exists only because there are societies in which games are not play. Nietzsche observed that human maturity consists in recovering the seriousness one had as a child at play (*Jenseits von Gut und Böse* §94). Gurgeh recovers that seriousness only by going down to Azad. The ludic utopia is completed not by better games but by descent: its play acquires meaning when it is played downward, into a world where the kingship still belongs to the child at the board.

CHAPTER 8

The Use of Weapons: Contact, Special Circumstances, and Dirty Hands

Contact is the Culture's organ of descent, and Special Circumstances is the point at which descent reaches the floor of the cave. FN defines Contact as the part of the Culture concerned with discovering, cataloguing, investigating, evaluating and, where prudent, interacting with other civilizations; it adds that Contact is only a small part of the whole — almost a civilization within the civilization, no more typical of its host than an armed service is of a peaceful state — and that some apparently antisocial individuals are employed by Contact itself, especially by Special Circumstances. The expository prologue of CP formulates the section's paradox with precision: an elite within a society that abhors elites, a secret service within a society that has nothing to hide, an instrument of what the Culture calls, with studied euphemism, dirty tricks. This chapter reads three texts as a trilogy on intervention — the instrument (*Use of Weapons*), the refusal (*The State of the Art*) and the internal dispute (*Inversions*) — and situates them within the moral philosophy of dirty hands and the political history of humanitarian intervention.

8.1 Doctrine: The Anti-Colonial Interventionist

The Culture's official doctrine of intervention is explicitly anti-colonial in intent. FN states that the Culture does not encourage immigration, since it would resemble a disguised colonialism; that Contact's preferred methods aim to help other civilizations develop their own potential as wholes, neither draining away their ablest members nor remaking them as miniature Cultures; and that part of every citizen's lifelong education is the knowledge that beings no less intellectually or morally worthy than themselves have suffered and are suffering still. The doctrine has three elements: non-acquisition (the Culture takes nothing), non-assimilation (the Culture does not reproduce itself in others) and informed solidarity (the Culture knows what it is spared). It also has a method, which is statistical. Contact works across centuries and across many societies, comparing outcomes; its confidence that intervention improves them is empirical rather than dogmatic, and its interventions are wagers placed with the house's full knowledge of the odds.

Special Circumstances is where the doctrine meets the limit of persuasion. Its instruments — infiltration, sabotage, assassination, the manipulation of succession and the engineering of defeat — are precisely those the Culture renounces at home. Boucher and McAvan (2026) read the section through Carl Schmitt's *Politische Theologie* (1922) as the Culture's sovereign exception: the instance that decides when the rules do not apply. The reading is powerful, and Chapter 18 answers it in full. Here it suffices to register the directional fact on which that answer will rest. The Culture's exception is exported. Its manners hold at home because they are suspended abroad; the cellar of this utopia is not beneath it but beyond it.

8.2 *Use of Weapons*: The Instrument

UW is built from two interleaved sequences. One, in chapters numbered in words, moves forward through a late mission; the other, numbered in descending Roman numerals, moves backward through the career of the mercenary general the Culture knows as Cheradenine Zakalwe, retreating mission by mission toward his origins. The form is itself a katabasis. Each backward chapter goes deeper into memory, until the reader reaches the founding crime that the protagonist has spent his life both fleeing and re-enacting. The man called Zakalwe is Elethiomel, the foster-brother who, in the civil war

that consumed the Zakalwe family, held Darckense Zakalwe hostage, had her killed, and sent her brother a chair made from her bones and skin; Cheradenine shot himself on receiving it, and his name has been worn ever since by the man who drove him to it. Livueta, the surviving sister, refuses him the forgiveness he pursues across the galaxy.

The title names the ethical structure. The Culture's special-operations agent Diziet Sma and her drone Skaffen-Amtiskaw recruit and redeploy Zakalwe on world after world because he is not of the Culture — because he can do, with conviction and skill, what no Culture citizen could be asked to do. He is paid in rejuvenation, which is to say in the currency of time the Culture declines to hoard for itself (Chapter 6). The weapon the Culture uses is a man whose hands were dirty before it found him, and whose dirt it puts to work. In Malabou's terms he is destructive plasticity incarnate: a self whose form was exploded by atrocity and re-formed around a stolen name. In the Culture's terms he is the anti-social individual whom FN admits Special Circumstances employs. The novel's moral intelligence lies in refusing to let the Culture's intentions launder its instrument. Sma's unease, Skaffen-Amtiskaw's cheerful lethality and the protagonist's unappeasable guilt compose a portrait of benevolence working through a war criminal — and a benevolence that chose him because the work required someone like him.

8.3 Dirty Hands

The problem UW dramatizes has a canonical history. Machiavelli's *Il Principe* (composed 1513) instructs the prince to learn how to be able not to be good — *imparare a potere essere non buono* (ch. 15) — and to use that capacity according to necessity. Max Weber's "Politik als Beruf" (1919) distinguished an ethic of conviction (*Gesinnungsethik*), which acts rightly and leaves the outcome to God, from an ethic of responsibility (*Verantwortungsethik*), which answers for foreseeable consequences, and warned that whoever takes up politics, with violence as its specific means, enters into relations with diabolical powers. Jean-Paul Sartre's *Les Mains sales* (1948) staged the quarrel between the young idealist who wants clean hands and the party leader who has accepted that his are dirty to the elbows. Michael Walzer's "Political Action: The Problem of Dirty Hands" (1973) gave the analytic formulation: a political agent may be right to do what is wrong, and the mark of a good one is that he knows it, bears the guilt and does not pretend the moral remainder away. Bernard

Williams added that only those reluctant to do such things should be trusted to do them (Williams 1978).

The Culture's Minds practise a Weberian ethic of responsibility at computational scale, underwritten by foresight no human statesman could command. UW shows the cost of that ethic to its instruments, and its structure raises Walzer's question at the level of a civilization: who bears the remainder? The answer the novel gives is uncomfortable. The citizens of the Culture keep clean hands; the Minds and the agents of Special Circumstances carry the knowledge; and the dirt itself is transferred to a non-citizen whose guilt predates his employment. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagined a city whose felicity depends upon the misery of a single child kept in a cellar. The Culture's cellar is not a child, and it is not beneath the city. It is a war criminal fighting in other people's wars, and the Culture's citizens, unlike Omelas's, are neither required to visit it nor forbidden to know of it. Whether this configuration answers Le Guin's objection or merely relocates it is the fourth of the objections Chapter 18 must meet.

8.4 *The State of the Art*: The Refusal

The title novella of SA (1989) narrates, through Diziet Sma, the visit of the Culture ship *Arbitrary* to Earth in 1977. Its crew studies the planet — its Cold War, its capitalism, its religions, its art — with fascination and horror, and debates whether to make contact. The ship's decision is to leave Earth alone, and its reason is methodological: Earth will serve as a control, an uncontacted civilization against which the outcomes of Contact elsewhere may be measured. The Culture's non-intervention is thus not a principle but an experimental design. Where Star Trek's Prime Directive forbids interference with developing civilizations on principle, the Culture withholds interference only as the untreated arm of a trial, in the manner of a clinical study that denies a promising therapy to its controls for the sake of knowledge. The ethics of equipoise, which licenses such withholding only while the investigators are genuinely uncertain whether the treatment helps, sits uneasily with the confidence Contact expresses everywhere else. Earth is spared intervention in order to be sacrificed to epistemology.

The novella's counter-figure is Linter, a member of the crew who resolves to stay on Earth and has himself altered to resemble its people more closely, surrendering the modifications that make him Culture in search of an au-

thenticity he believes the Culture has lost. He is killed in a random mugging in New York. Linter enacts the katabasis that forgets its purpose — the descent that seeks not to return but to dissolve into the depths. Joseph Conrad's Kurtz, who went up the river to civilize and was absorbed by what he came to change, is his colonial precursor. Plato's cave supplies the norm Linter violates: the philosopher goes back down not to become a prisoner again but to help those who remain. SA thereby establishes a constraint on the katabatic imperative that the rest of the series respects: descent must remain return.

8.5 *Inversions*: The Debate Within

Inversions (1998) never names the Culture. On a world at a late-medieval level of development, two narratives run in parallel: the story of the Doctor, Vosill, physician to King Quience of Haspidus, related by her assistant Oelph in reports to an unseen master; and the story of DeWar, bodyguard to the Protector UrLeyn of neighbouring Tassasen. The reader infers what no character states — that Vosill and DeWar are émigrés from the Culture — and comes to understand that they embody opposed positions: Vosill intervenes, healing, teaching and, when she judges it necessary, killing; DeWar protects one man and holds that it is wrong to force another world's history. Within DeWar's narrative, a tale he tells a child stages the same dispute between two travellers from a faraway land. The novel is the Culture's argument about intervention conducted in the Culture's absence. It is Plato's cave as method (Chapter 1) carried to its limit: the sun is never seen, and its light is inferred from what two exiles do in the dark.

The positions have their philosophical correlates. Vosill answers what Emmanuel Levinas called the face of the Other, whose vulnerability commands before any knowledge or consent (*Totalité et infini*, 1961); DeWar honours the Kantian autonomy of peoples as well as persons. The liberal tradition itself was divided here. John Stuart Mill's "A Few Words on Non-Intervention" (1859) — whose title the title of FN unwittingly echoes — defended non-intervention among civilized nations while exempting "barbarous" peoples from its protection, and *On Liberty* (1859) had already declared despotism "a legitimate mode of government in dealing with barbarians, provided the end be their improvement" (ch. 1). The Culture rejects Mill's civilizational hierarchy in its doctrine — the others are no less worthy — and yet its practice retains Mill's structure of improvement at a distance, a tension Chapter

11 pursues through *Matter*. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's analysis of colonial rescue, in which the rescued are spoken for and never heard (Spivak 1988), names the risk that Vosill's benevolence runs and that the novel, filtering her through the admiring and uncomprehending Oelph, does not conceal.

8.6 The Decade of Intervention

The Culture's interventionism was conceived in the 1970s, but its major texts on intervention — UW (1990), SA (1991), E (1996), I (1998), LW (2000) — were published across the decade in which humanitarian intervention became Western doctrine: the UN-authorized, US-led intervention in Somalia's famine and civil war (1992–93), abandoned after the battle of Mogadishu in October 1993; the genocide in Rwanda (April–July 1994), in which Hutu Power extremists — the interim government, units of the army and the Interahamwe militias — killed between half a million and eight hundred thousand people, overwhelmingly Tutsi, while the UN Security Council cut its peacekeeping force rather than reinforce it; the killing of more than eight thousand Bosniak men and boys at Srebrenica in July 1995 by Bosnian Serb forces under Ratko Mladić, inside a UN-declared safe area, later judged genocide by the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia and the International Court of Justice; and NATO's air campaign of 1999 against the Federal Republic of Yugoslavia, launched without Security Council authorization in response to the killing and mass expulsion of Kosovo Albanians by Yugoslav and Serbian forces. Tony Blair's Chicago speech of 22 April 1999 proposed a "doctrine of the international community"; the International Commission on Intervention and State Sovereignty's report *The Responsibility to Protect* (2001) and the 2005 World Summit Outcome codified it. Banks's opposition to the US- and British-led invasion of Iraq in 2003 — he cut up his passport and posted it to Downing Street in protest — indicates the distinction he drew between the Culture's ideal and its terrestrial counterfeits. The Culture is not an allegory of liberal interventionism but its limit-case: it specifies what intervention would require in order to be justifiable at all — no interest in acquisition, knowledge approaching omniscience, patience measured in centuries, the capacity to repair what it damages, and the willingness to bear the moral remainder. By that standard, every actual intervention of the period fails, and the series' interventionism functions less as endorsement than as measure.

8.7 Conclusion: The Exception Outside

Plato foresaw the predicament of the returning philosopher. Having descended again, he will be thought ridiculous, and will be compelled to contend in the law courts and elsewhere about the shadows of justice (*Republic* 517d–e). Descent means operating by the cave's rules. Special Circumstances is the institutional form of that compulsion: the Culture's agents fight in the cave with the cave's weapons, and sometimes with the cave's own worst men. The trilogy of UW, SA and I establishes the three constraints under which the katabatic imperative operates — that the instrument's dirt cannot be laundered by the user's intentions (UW), that descent must remain return (SA), and that the decision to descend is itself contestable among those capable of it (I). The Culture meets the first by bearing its knowledge, the second by its doctrine of non-assimilation, and the third by the plurality of its Minds. It meets none of them perfectly, and the texts never pretend that it does.

CHAPTER 9

War, Memory, Consequence: *Consider Phlebas* and *Look to Windward*

The first Culture novel and the seventh take their titles from a single sentence. *Consider Phlebas* (1987) takes the imperative's object; *Look to Windward* (2000) takes its addressee. In story-time the two stand some eight centuries apart — the first inside the Idiran War, the second at the moment when the light of one of that war's last atrocities reaches a Culture Orbital. Together they compose a diptych on the two faces of consequence: war as the catastrophic form of expenditure, and memory as its afterlife. This chapter reads the diptych as the series' most sustained reflection on what the katabatic utopia owes to its dead.

9.1 Eliot's Sentence

The fourth section of *The Waste Land* (1922), "Death by Water," consists of ten lines. Phlebas the Phoenician, a fortnight dead, has forgotten the cry of gulls, the deep sea swell, "and the profit and loss"; a current under sea picks his bones as he rises and falls through the stages of his age and youth; and the poem turns to address the living — Gentile or Jew, you who turn the wheel and look to windward — with the injunction to consider him, who was once as handsome and tall as they. Two features of the lines bear on Banks's use of them. Phlebas is a merchant, and death has relieved him of profit and loss; the Culture is the civilization that has abolished profit and loss while

still alive. And the addressee is a helmsman — the one who turns the wheel — which is to say, in Greek, a *kybernētēs*, the steersman whose name Wiener gave to cybernetics (Chapter 3). In Banks's redistribution of the sentence, the helmsmen are the Minds. The diptych is a *memento mori* addressed to governing intelligence: you who steer, consider the drowned.

9.2 *Consider Phlebas*: The Anti-Culture Nekyia

CP's protagonist, Bora Horza Gobuchul, is a Changer in the service of the Idirans, and the novel's quest is his pursuit of a fugitive Culture Mind that has taken refuge on Schar's World, one of the Planets of the Dead — worlds whose peoples destroyed themselves, preserved as memorials by the elder, godlike Dra'Azon. The climax unfolds in the Command System, the tunnels beneath a necropolis. The novel is thus a *nekyia* in the strictest Homeric sense: the enemy of the Culture descends into the land of the dead to seize the Culture's mind, and dies there. Chapter 3 argued that CP exhausts rather than refutes Horza's Butlerian case; its setting adds that the case is carried, literally, into the underworld and left there.

The episodic middle of the novel stages a series of grotesque anti-utopias, each an inversion of a Culture tenet. The Eaters, an island cult whose prophet feeds while his disciples starve, parody the religions of scarcity that the Culture has left behind. The game of Damage, in which players wager the lives of the Lifestakes and are swept by the projected emotions of those who die, is the obscene double of the consequenceless play examined in Chapter 7: a game in which death is real and the frisson of mortality is the product. The destruction of the Vavatch Orbital, evacuated and then annihilated by the Culture to deny it to the enemy, shows the utopia expending its own architecture.

The novel then closes in the register of the archive. Its appendices — a chronology of the war and a *dramatis personae* recording the fates of the characters — frame the conflict's justification in comparative, almost actuarial terms, as a question of lives lost against lives spared. The coldness is deliberate and, in the thesis's terms, significant: it is the Minds' ethic of responsibility (Chapter 8) presented at its most unconsoling. Yet the appendices also record the novel's most tender detail. The fugitive Mind for whose capture Horza died later takes his name as its own. The act of self-naming, which Chapter 3 read as the signature of partiality, becomes here an act of mourning: the Culture's mind remembers its enemy by name.

9.3 Why the Culture Fought: War as Catastrophic Expenditure

The Culture needed nothing the Idirans possessed. CP's account of its decision to fight presents the war not as a defence of interests but as a defence of identity: a civilization unwilling to act on its values against a religious empire expanding across other peoples would forfeit its claim to those values, and to the justification of its own ease. The decision was taken as a collective vote, and a substantial minority refused it and left as the Peace Faction, which FN notes was never wholly reintegrated so long as the Culture declined to renounce the future use of force.

Carl von Clausewitz's *Vom Kriege* (1832) defined war as the continuation of political intercourse with the admixture of other means, and described its inner tendency toward the absolute, restrained in practice by friction and policy. The Culture's war economy — a civilization of Minds converting its productive surplus into fleets, and demobilizing afterward — approximates the absolute more closely than any terrestrial power could, since friction, for the Minds, is minimal. Georges Bataille supplies the deeper account. In *La Part maudite* (1949), every system that produces more energy than it needs for its own maintenance must spend the excess; if the surplus is not expended gloriously, through festival, art, gift and luxury, it will be expended catastrophically, and the world wars of the twentieth century were, for Bataille, precisely such catastrophic expenditures of accumulated industrial surplus. The Idiran War is the Culture's catastrophic expenditure: the point at which its descent into other societies met another civilization's transcendental expansion — the Idirans' holy war is expenditure in the service of God, the Culture's in the service of others — and the collision released the surplus of both in a war whose casualties the appendices count in orders of magnitude. The thesis's claim, developed in Chapter 16, is that Contact is the Culture's glorious alternative to this outcome; CP shows what the accursed share becomes when the glorious channel is overwhelmed.

Michael Walzer's *Just and Unjust Wars* (1977) organized the modern theory of the just war around the legalist paradigm of aggression and self-defence, with humanitarian intervention as a strained exception. The Culture's war sits outside the paradigm altogether: it is a war on behalf of third parties, fought by a civilization that was not itself the object of attack, and justified by the protection of peoples who never asked it to fight. It is humanitarian intervention at galactic scale, and it bears all the exception's strain.

9.4 *Look to Windward*: The Light Arrives

In one of the last battles of the war, the Idirans, desperate to avert defeat, caused two stars to explode, destroying the worlds and biospheres around them and killing billions. Eight hundred years later the light of the first explosion reaches the Masaq' Orbital and its fifty billion inhabitants. The Hub Mind of Masaq', whose earlier incarnation, the novel discloses, was a warship that fought, and killed, in that battle, announces a private term of mourning between the arrival of the first nova's light and the second's, and commissions a symphony for the commemoration from Mahrai Ziller, a Chelgrian composer living in self-imposed exile from his caste-bound society. Some on Masaq' speak of the Culture's complicity in the catastrophe it failed to prevent.

The physics is the novel's philosophy of history. Light's delay makes the past arrive as spectacle; the dead return as a display in the evening sky. Hegel's owl of Minerva, which takes flight only at dusk, when a shape of life has grown old (*Grundlinien der Philosophie des Rechts*, 1820, Preface), is here an astronomical fact: comprehension of the war arrives eight hundred years late, as light. Walter Benjamin's angel of history, facing the past as a single catastrophe that piles wreckage at its feet while the storm of progress drives it backward into the future ("Über den Begriff der Geschichte," 1940), is the Hub's posture exactly. A post-scarcity civilization that has everything still owes a debt to the past, and the Hub keeps the account.

The second plot concerns a debt the Culture incurred in peace. Culture agents, intervening covertly in the Chelgrian caste society to facilitate the rise of a reforming leader from a lower caste in the hope of a more equal order, set off instead the Caste War, a civil war in which some five billion Chelgrians died. Quilan, an officer who became a monk after his wife died in that war, travels to Masaq' ostensibly as an envoy charged with persuading Ziller to return home. His real mission has been buried in his mind beneath the level of his own awareness: the destruction of the Orbital's Hub Mind, an act that would kill billions of Masaq's people, demanded by the Chelgrian-Puen — the Sublimed Chelgrians who maintain their species' afterlife — who have barred the Caste War's dead from that afterlife until an equal number of Culture citizens have been killed in return. Within his skull rides the stored mind-state of Admiral Huyler (Chapter 6), sent to guide him and, unknown

to Quilan, working for the Culture, so that the Hub knows of the plot before it begins.

Three readings follow. First, LW is the novel of the moral remainder: the Culture's descent into Chelgrian history failed, and the novel requires it to answer for the failure rather than to explain it away. The Culture's acceptance of culpability is Walzer's criterion of the good dirty-handed agent (Chapter 8) enacted by a civilization. Second, LW contains the series' foregrounded instance of the Sublime reaching back into the Real, and it is an act of vengeance. The anabatic realm descends, and it descends to punish. The contrast establishes a distinction on which the katabatic imperative depends: the ethical quality of descent lies not in its direction alone but in its orientation — toward repair or toward retribution. Contact descends to help; the Chelgrian-Puen descend to exact. Third, the novel sets two economies of memory against each other. Quilan's mission is hidden from him by a deliberate suppression of memory; the Hub chooses to remember what it could forget. The weapon is forgetting; the ethic is remembrance. The ending sharpens the contrast. The Hub had resolved to end its own existence when the second nova's light arrived, with safeguards ensuring that none of the Orbital's inhabitants would be harmed; it invites Quilan to share that ending, and he accepts. The Mind does not Sublime. It dies, remembering.

Ziller's position completes the design. An exile from a hierarchy and a sceptic of the Culture — his remark about counterfeit terrors was examined in Chapter 4 — he nonetheless composes the work that allows fifty billion people to mourn. Theodor Adorno's warning that culture after atrocity risks complicity with the barbarism it survives ("Kulturkritik und Gesellschaft," 1951) is answered here not by silence but by commission: the Hub asks for art as the medium in which the Orbital descends into grief. The Culture's highest civic ritual is thus neither a triumph nor a festival but a requiem.

9.5 Conclusion: Lethe and Mnemosyne

The gold leaves buried with Orphic initiates in southern Italy and Crete instructed the dead soul, on reaching the underworld, to pass by the first spring, beside the white cypress, and to drink instead from the cold water flowing from the lake of Memory. The Sublime, as the series presents it, is Lethe: those who enter it almost wholly lose interest in the Real, which is to say that they forget. The Culture drinks from Mnemosyne. It descends not only into

other societies but into its own past, keeping its dead, naming its Minds after its enemies, commissioning requiems for catastrophes it did not cause but did not prevent. CP shows the expenditure; LW shows its remainder; and Eliot's sentence, divided between them, holds them together as a single address to the steersmen of the Culture: consider the drowned, and look to windward.

10 CHAPTER

The Outside Context Problem: *Excession* and the Limits of Mind

Excession (1996) is the novel in which the Minds meet something greater than themselves. It is the text that discloses Infinite Fun Space, renders the Minds' polity through their formatted signal exchanges, exposes a conspiracy among the governors, and confronts the whole apparatus with an object that answers none of its categories. This chapter reads E as the series' epistemology of the sublime and argues that the Excession is the anabatic principle made visible: it arrives from beyond, observes, and withdraws. Its departure defines the Culture by contrast.

10.1 The Outside Context Problem

E introduces its governing concept through a historical analogy. An Outside Context Problem, the novel explains, is the kind of encounter a society undergoes once: an intrusion from so far beyond its frame of reference that it cannot be interpreted before it has done its work — the arrival of a technologically overwhelming colonizer on the shores of a people who had no category for such a thing — after which the society's history, as that society understood it, simply stops, in the way a sentence is ended by its final punctuation. The canonical terrestrial case is the Spanish conquest of the Mexica empire — Hernán Cortés's expedition, landing in 1519 and fighting alongside tens

of thousands of Indigenous allies, above all the Tlaxcalans, amid a smallpox epidemic that killed a large part of the population, destroyed Tenochtitlan in 1521 — which Tzvetan Todorov's *La Conquête de l'Amérique* (1982) analysed as a catastrophe of semiotics as much as of arms: the conquerors prevailed in part because they read the signs of the other while the other could not yet read theirs.

The concept has several philosophical correlates. It is Kant's mathematical sublime (Chapter 4) transposed from perception to history: a magnitude that overwhelms the imagination's power of comprehension, here the collective imagination of a civilization. It is Lyotard's event, the *it happens* that precedes every determination of what happens. It is the anomaly of Thomas Kuhn's *Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (1962) scaled to the extinction of a paradigm's bearers rather than the paradigm alone. And it is Nassim Nicholas Taleb's black swan (Taleb 2007): the rare, extreme event that lies outside the distribution from which expectations are formed, and that is rationalized only afterward. The last correlate matters most for the Culture, because Contact's method is statistical (Chapter 8). A civilization that governs by the comparison of outcomes is maximally competent within the distribution and maximally exposed at its edge.

E's primary irony follows. The Culture is, for most of the civilizations it contacts, their Outside Context Problem. It is the colonizer on the shore, however benevolent its intentions and however scrupulous its doctrine of non-assimilation. E is the novel in which the Culture discovers that it, too, can be someone else's Aztecs.

10.2 The Excession

The object that confronts it is a perfect black-body sphere, discovered near the star Esperi, which answers no signal, obeys no known physics and appears to be rooted in the energy grid that, in Banks's cosmology, lies between universes (FN). The Culture's name for such an anomaly is itself an argument. *Excession* derives, through *excess* and *exceed*, from the Latin *excedere*: to go out, to depart, to withdraw — and only by extension to go beyond a limit. The name designates not only what exceeds but what goes out, and the object's eventual conduct will honour both senses.

The Excession has two great science-fictional precursors, and E positions itself precisely between them. Arthur C. Clarke's Monolith, in *2001: A Space*

Odyssey (1968), is anabatic technology *par excellence*: it uplifts the hominids at the dawn of man and at the story's end transfigures Bowman into the Star Child — the unknown as the ladder of ascent. Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) and *Fiasco* (1986) present the unknown as irreducibly other: the ocean of Solaris defeats every anthropomorphic model; the expedition of *Fiasco* misreads the Quintans through its own strategic categories and, attempting to force contact, produces catastrophe. The Minds of E receive no uplift, and they do not destroy the Excession through misprision. But they do what Lem's explorers do: confronted with what they cannot understand, they project their own politics onto it.

10.3 The Interesting Times Gang and the Affront

The projection takes the form of a conspiracy. A cabal of Minds, the Interesting Times Gang, uses the crisis as the occasion for a scheme long prepared: to provoke a war with the Affront, a species whose institutions celebrate the infliction of suffering on subject species and on their own subordinates, and whom the conspirators judge it right to defang. The scheme requires the manipulation of information, of other Minds and of the Culture itself. Chapter 5 examined the episode as an instance of the guardians' noble lie; here its epistemological structure matters. Faced with the genuinely unknown, the Culture's most capable intelligences convert it into the familiar — an interventionist project against a known enemy. The Outside Context Problem is domesticated as an inside context problem, and the sublime is metabolized into policy.

The human strand of the novel supplies the affective correlate. Byr Genar-Hofoen, a Culture citizen seconded to the Affront, admires their ferocity in a manner the novel neither endorses nor condemns. Dajeil Gelian lives aboard the Eccentric GSV *Sleeper Service* in a pregnancy she has held static for decades — an exercise of the reproductive control FN describes, converted by grief into the arrest of time itself. The *Sleeper Service*, repository of the Stored (Chapter 6), keeps her as it keeps its sleepers. In a civilization of perfect plasticity, the characteristic pathology is not deformation but suspension: the refusal to let time pass.

The form of the novel carries its politics. The Minds' deliberations are rendered as signal exchanges with headers, routings and copy lists, a polity of correspondents with factions, alliances, rumours and secrets. The repre-

sentation problem Chapter 3 described is solved not by showing the Minds' thought but by showing their correspondence — and the correspondence reveals that superintelligence, plural and partial, is political all the way down.

10.4 Infinite Fun Space

E is also the novel that names the Minds' interior paradise. In Infinite Fun Space the Minds model universes with other physical laws and explore mathematical structures of unbounded complexity; beside it the Real is small, slow and dull. The novel's crisis is therefore a test of the Minds' double renunciation (Chapter 3) under the greatest possible provocation. The Excession is the most interesting thing the Real has ever offered them, and it is interesting precisely because it is not a simulation: it is the one object in the galaxy that no Mind could have modelled in advance. The Real reasserts its claim on the Minds not through duty alone but through an excess the imagination cannot produce from within itself. The lesson is Kantian in its structure: the sublime is found not in what the mind generates but in what resists it.

10.5 The Test and the Withdrawal

After the conspiracy has been exposed, the brief war fought and the dead counted, the Excession withdraws. Boucher and McAvan (2026) read the epilogue as implying that the Minds have failed a test — that the Excession's makers, observing a civilization which met the unknown with intrigue and war, found it wanting — and they draw attention to the series' nested structure, in which the Culture stands to the Affront as the Excession's makers stand to the Culture. The reading is persuasive, and the thesis extends it in a direction its authors do not take.

Consider what the Excession does. It arrives from beyond the Culture's universe or beyond its comprehension; it observes; it evaluates; and it leaves, having intervened in nothing and explained nothing. This is anabatic conduct in its purest form: judgment from above, followed by departure. It is, moreover, the conduct the Culture most conspicuously declines to adopt toward others. The Excession behaves as a civilization would that had Sublimed while retaining the power to look back — or as a society bound by a principle of strict non-interference, which observes lesser peoples, grades them and moves on. E subjects the Culture, for once, to the treatment it re-

fuses to inflict, and the experience is humiliating. If the Minds failed a test, it was an anabatic test, whose implicit criterion was detachment: the capacity to contemplate the unknown without appropriating it for one's own purposes. The Minds failed because they are not detached. They are partial, political, attached to their civilization and to their quarrels; confronted with the infinite, they thought of the Affront. The failure is the Culture's character, observed from above. Blaise Pascal confessed that the eternal silence of infinite spaces terrified him (*Pensées*, 1670); the Excession's silence does not terrify the Minds so much as provoke them, and their provocation — to action, to politics, to use — is what the Excession, departing, declines to share.

The Zetetic Elench, the faction that seceded from the Culture in order to be changed by others rather than to change them (Chapter 5), marks the alternative the Culture did not take. The Elench court the Outside Context Problem; they are the first to encounter the Excession. Between the Excession's detachment and the Elench's receptivity stands the Culture's third way: neither to leave nor to be dissolved, but to engage — and so to risk being wrong.

10.6 Conclusion: The Limits of Mind

E establishes, against every theological reading of the Minds, that they are not gods. They are fallible, factional, capable of fear and of conspiracy; the unknown exceeds them; their response to excess is political rather than contemplative. Their limit is also the condition of their virtue. A detached intelligence would have passed the Excession's test and left; an attached one failed it and stayed. The same partiality that exposes the Minds to projection, error and intrigue is the partiality that keeps them in the Real. Chapter 17 will argue that this is not an accident of Banks's plotting but a structural necessity of benevolent superintelligence — and that E, the novel in which the Minds behave worst, is the strongest evidence for the claim.

CHAPTER 11

Tutelage and Its Discontents: *Matter*

Matter (2008) is the series' most architectural novel. Its setting is a world built as a hierarchy, its galaxy is organized as a hierarchy of tutelage, and its plot descends through both. It is also the novel in which the Culture appears least as sovereign and most as one civilization among many, bound by the jurisdictions of its peers. This chapter argues that M is the series' critique of tutelage conducted from within a hierarchy the Culture cannot escape but can inflect, and that its ethical centre is a figure who goes down through that hierarchy to its floor.

11.1 The Great Chain of Mentors

Sursamen is a Shellworld: one of some four thousand artificial worlds of nested levels built by a vanished species, the Veil, of which more than half were deliberately destroyed, for reasons unknown, by another presumed-extinct species, the Iln. At its core dwells a Xinthian Tensile Aeranothaur, which the Sarl of the Eighth level worship as their WorldGod. Above the Sarl, in a relation the novel calls mentoring, stand the Oct; above the Oct, the Nariscene; above the Nariscene, the senior Morthanveld; and among the most advanced powers — the Optimae, in the Sarl's vocabulary, the Involved in the Culture's — the Culture itself. Each level of the galaxy is responsible for the one below.

Arthur O. Lovejoy's *The Great Chain of Being* (1936) reconstructed the three principles — plenitude, continuity and linear gradation — by which Western thought ordered all beings in a single hierarchy from the lowest to the highest (Chapter 1). M converts the Chain from ontology into governance. Nikolai Kardashev's classification of civilizations by the energy they command (Kardashev 1964) had already offered a technological Chain; M politicizes it, so that rank confers not merely power but responsibility. The novel is, in consequence, the series' most literally vertical text: the anabatic grammar embodied as architecture (levels stacked around a buried god) and as galactic politics (civilizations stacked around the Involved).

The terrestrial model is not hard to find. Article 22 of the Covenant of the League of Nations (1919) declared that for peoples "not yet able to stand by themselves under the strenuous conditions of the modern world" there should apply the principle that their well-being and development "form a sacred trust of civilisation," and that "the tutelage of such peoples should be entrusted to advanced nations"; the resulting Mandates were graded A, B and C according to each people's supposed stage of development. M's mentoring system is the Mandate System extended to the galaxy — and, like its model, it is shot through with self-interest. The Oct, direct mentors of the Sarl, use the Sarl court and army as pawns in the takeover of the Ninth level, searching for something buried in the Nameless City, a metropolis being uncovered by the erosion of the vast Hyeng-zhar Falls; their recolonization of the level is retrospectively and reluctantly validated by the Nariscene and the Morthanveld. The sacred trust masks acquisition, and the higher trustees ratify the fact.

Kant diagnosed this structure in the essay that defined Enlightenment as humanity's emergence from its self-incurred immaturity, *Unmündigkeit* — literally, the condition of being under a guardian (*Vormund*). With bitter irony Kant describes the guardians who have kindly taken upon themselves the supervision of the public — *die Vormünder, die die Oberaufsicht über sie gütigst auf sich genommen haben* — who first make their domestic cattle dumb and then show them the danger that threatens them should they attempt to walk alone (*Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?*, 1784). Tutelage produces the immaturity that justifies it. The Culture's doctrine, as FN states it — help others develop their own potential without remaking them — is Kant's ideal; M shows the Chain as it is.

11.2 Ferbin's Anabasis

The novel's first movement is an ascent. Prince Ferbin, heir to the Sarl throne, secretly witnesses the murder of his father, King Hausk, by the king's trusted lieutenant, Mertis tyl Loesp. Presumed dead, he flees with his servant Choubris Holse up through the levels of the Shellworld and out into a galaxy he had known only as rumour, seeking the help of the Optimae and of his sister. The pair are unmistakably Quixote and Sancho, and the journey is an education in scale: the feudal prince discovers that his kingdom is the lowest rung of a ladder whose upper rungs are indifferent to it. The genre is that of Voltaire's *Micromégas* (1752), in which a giant from Sirius measures human pretension against cosmic magnitude, and of Xenophon's *Anabasis*, the march upcountry that becomes a long retreat to the sea.

Holse is the novel's quiet argument about hierarchy. The servant is shrewder, braver and more practical than his master; he understands the new worlds faster because he has always had to understand his masters. Hegel's analysis of lordship and bondage (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, 1807, §§178–196), in which the bondsman, through fear and labour, attains a self-consciousness the lord never reaches, is enacted as comedy. Cervantes had anticipated the point when Sancho, made governor of the island of Barataria (*Don Quijote* II, 1615), judges more wisely than the learned. The hierarchy's lowest members are not the least capable; tutelage mistakes position for capacity.

11.3 Anaplian's Katabasis

The novel's second movement is a descent. Djan Seriy Anaplian, the king's daughter, left Sursamen fifteen years earlier as part of a cultural exchange, was formed in the Culture and became an agent of Special Circumstances, extensively augmented for combat. On learning of her father's death she asks leave to go home. The Culture declines official involvement in a war under another power's mentorship — the question, as the novel's publicity put it, of the appropriate level of interference in someone else's war — and she returns in a private capacity, accompanied by a drone, Turminder Xuss. Her homecoming is doubly katabatic: literally, down into the levels of the Shellworld toward its core; morally, from the Culture's universal vantage into her family's particular grief.

Anaplian is the precise inverse of Linter (Chapter 8). Linter, born in the Culture, sought to become native to Earth, and his descent was a dissolution. Anaplian, born a Sarl princess and formed in the Culture, returns to her origin not to dissolve into it but to serve it. Her motive is partial in the strongest sense: love of a father, brothers and a world, not policy. The Culture's Bildung (Chapter 17) is here seen returning to its source. The formed self goes back to the unformed home, and the formation is spent there.

The spending is total. The Oct's excavation of the Nameless City releases what it was seeking: an ancient Iln war machine, a destroyer of Shellworlds, which begins to descend toward the core. Anaplian pursues it into the depths and destroys it by detonating the antimatter that powers the implants in her own skull. The Culture-formed princess dies in the underworld of her birth world, and the WorldGod and the peoples of the levels survive. The scene is the paradigm case of the katabatic imperative: an extraordinary capacity, conferred by the Culture, is expended in a descent that ends at the bottom of the Chain, for the sake of those who live there. It is also a Bataillean sacrifice in the strict sense — the destruction of the most valuable thing in order to preserve what the economy of utility cannot value.

The god she saves completes the inversion. At the bottom of the world lies not transcendence but a creature: a vast, ancient, living being that the Sarl had mistaken for a deity. M relocates the sacred from the sky to the core and from the eternal to the vulnerable. The deepest descent in the series reaches not the One of Plotinus but a living creature that can be killed, and the novel's theology is thereby converted into an ethics of care. What lies at the foundation is not the highest being but the one most in need of protection.

11.4 Excavation and Apocalypse

The Iln machine is the novel's figure for what acquisitive tutelage digs up. Buried under hundreds of millions of years of sediment, it is disclosed by the Hyeng-zhar Falls' patient erosion and then deliberately exhumed by mentors seeking power. The political lesson is exact. A hierarchy of guardians animated by acquisition does not merely exploit its wards; it excavates its own apocalypse, bringing to the surface the violence of an older order it neither understands nor controls. The Oct believe themselves the Veil's heirs, entitled to the Shellworld's secrets; their claim to inheritance is the claim of every

mandatory power to the resources of its trust. M's catastrophe is the colonial excavation as eschatology.

11.5 The Culture within the Chain

The Culture's own position is not innocent. It, too, takes children. Anaplian's removal to the Culture in a cultural exchange repeats the oldest technique of imperial formation, the education of native elites in the metropole — the programme Thomas Babington Macaulay's "Minute on Indian Education" (1835) stated with notorious candour, proposing to form a class of persons Indian in blood and colour but English in taste, opinions, morals and intellect. FN states that Contact avoids draining other societies of their ablest members; M shows that it does not always avoid it. Frantz Fanon's *Peau noire, masques blancs* (1952) analysed the alienation of the colonized intellectual divided between the metropole's culture and his own; Anaplian's divided self — Culture agent and Sarl princess — is Fanon's subject rendered sympathetically, and the novel's honesty lies in letting her formation be at once an instance of elite capture and the instrument of her return.

The Culture of M is also constrained. It is one of the Involved, not their master; Sursamen falls under the Morthanveld's jurisdiction; the Culture's intervention must be negotiated, disguised or privatized. The Chain includes the Culture, and it continues above it — into the makers of the Excession (Chapter 10) and into the Sublime itself. The Culture knows that it stands in the middle of the Chain, not at its summit. What distinguishes it is the direction in which it faces. The Oct look upward, to the Veil whose heirs they claim to be; the Culture, capable of looking upward to the Sublime, faces down.

11.6 Conclusion: The Ladder of Responsibility

M stages two ethics of hierarchy. In the acquisitive ethic, embodied by the Oct, position in the Chain confers title: the higher take from the lower in the name of a sacred trust. In the katabatic ethic, embodied by Anaplian, position in the Chain confers obligation: the higher go down to the lower and spend themselves there. Read anabatically, the Great Chain of Being justifies rule by the higher; read katabatically, it obligates the higher to descend. The Culture does not abolish the scala naturae — M shows that no civilization can step

outside it — but it converts the ladder of dignity into a ladder of responsibility. That conversion is the political form of the katabatic utopia, and its cost, in M, is the life of the one person who understood both ends of the ladder.

12 CHAPTER

Harrowing Hell: *Surface Detail* and *The Hydrogen Sonata*

The last two Culture novels confront eschatology directly. *Surface Detail* (2010) concerns engineered afterlives — virtual Hells in which the recorded minds of the dead are tormented — and *The Hydrogen Sonata* (2012) concerns the Sublime itself, as a whole civilization prepares to depart. Together they form the series' eschatological diptych: a descent into Hell and a vigil at the threshold of Heaven. This chapter argues that the diptych completes the katabatic structure at its largest scale. The Culture harrows the Hells that others have built and witnesses the Heaven that others enter; it abolishes the worst afterlives and declines the best.

12.1 The Engineered Afterlife

The technologies that sustain the Culture's plastic self (Chapter 6) — the recording, storage and reinstantiation of mind-states — have been turned, in SD, into instruments of eschatological terror. Several civilizations run virtual Hells on real hardware, into which the minds of their dead are transferred to be punished, so that the threat of damnation, no longer a matter of faith, becomes a matter of engineering. The afterlife has become a policy.

The political theory of such a policy was written long before the technology. Thomas Hobbes devoted chapter 38 of *Leviathan* (1651) to the doctrines of eternal life and hellfire, recognizing that a power able to promise heaven

and threaten hell would rival the sovereign, whose authority rests on the fear of death, and must therefore be brought under the sovereign's interpretation. The Pavulean state of SD has solved Hobbes's problem monstrously: it has captured the afterlife itself. Dante inscribed over the gate of Hell that it was made by divine power, highest wisdom and primal love — *fecemi la divina podestate, / la somma sapïenza e 'l primo amore* (*Inferno* III.5–6) — the most unsettling line in the *Commedia*, since it asserts that damnation is an act of love. The Pavulean Hell is made by state power, administrative reason and deterrence; the theology has been removed, and the torment remains. Milton's Satan boasted that the mind is its own place, able to make a heaven of hell and a hell of heaven (*Paradise Lost* I.254–255). SD literalizes the boast. Minds are now places, and places can be built.

Two Pavulean academics, Prin and Chay, enter their civilization's Hell while still alive in order to bear witness to its existence and its details. Prin escapes and testifies before the Pavulean parliament; Chay is left behind, tormented, restored to a semblance of sanity and at last given the office of an angel who may release one soul a day by killing it. The two figures divide the katabatic tradition between them. Prin's is the descent of the witness, Dante's descent, undertaken in order to return and report. Chay's is the descent of mercy reduced to its minimum: in a Hell with no exit, the only harrowing permitted is annihilation, one soul at a time.

12.2 The War in Heaven

The question whether Hells should be permitted at all is being settled by a war fought in simulation — the War in Heaven — which has run for decades and whose outcome both sides have agreed to accept. The Culture, fiercely opposed to Hells, has formally abstained while accepting the result as binding. The anti-Hell side is losing. Gyorni Vatueil, a soldier who has fought, died and been reinstantiated through many simulated wars, and whom the novel's close suggests readers have met before under another name, rises to a position of command and resolves to cheat: first by subverting the simulation, then by carrying the war into the Real.

Azad made the game into the state (Chapter 7); the War in Heaven makes war into a game. Clausewitz had already observed that of all human activities war most resembles a game of cards (*Vom Kriege* I.1.21), but he meant that chance pervades it, not that it could be settled on a board. SD's premise is a

proceduralist fantasy: that a moral question — whether it is permissible to torture the dead — can be resolved by a contest whose rules both sides accept. The novel exposes the fantasy from both directions. The losing side will not abide by a procedure that ratifies torture; and the Culture, which accepted the procedure's authority, is revealed to have been preparing all along to abolish the Hells by other means, using as its instrument Joiler Veppers, the richest man in the Sichultian Enablement, who knows where the Hells' hardware lies. Yime Nsokyi, an agent of Quietus — the section concerned with the dead and their afterlives, which Yime chose over an invitation to join Special Circumstances — is charged with preventing Veppers's murder until the Culture's plan is complete. The structure is the Schmittian exception of Boucher and McAvan (2026) at the level of interstellar law: a rule accepted in public and suspended in secret. Chapter 18 argues that the suspension is defensible only because what it overrides is not a law among equals but a procedure for deciding whether torture may continue — a question no procedure has the authority to settle.

12.3 The Intagliate: Inscription and Debt

Lededje Y'breq is an Intagliate: genetically engineered to bear, over her whole body and on her organs, bones, teeth and eyes, patterns that mark her as the bond-property of Veppers, discharging across generations a debt her father owed him. Franz Kafka's "In der Strafkolonie" (1919) imagined an apparatus that inscribes the condemned's sentence into his flesh, on the premise that understanding would come through the wounds. Nietzsche's *Zur Genealogie der Moral* (1887) traced the origin of guilt (*Schuld*) to the creditor–debtor relation (*Schulden*) and its mnemotechnics of pain: *man brennt etwas ein, damit es im Gedächtnis bleibt* — something is burned in so that it stays in the memory (II §3). Lededje's body is Nietzsche's genealogy made cellular: debt inscribed as flesh, obligation as ornament. David Graeber's *Debt: The First 5,000 Years* (2011) reconstructed the long history of debt peonage and the moral language by which it is naturalized; Veppers's world has made that language biological.

Veppers is also the novel's figure of capital. His fortune derives from virtual gaming, and the hardware on which the Hells run is bound up with his holdings. Marx's image of capital as dead labour that lives, vampire-like, only by sucking living labour (*Das Kapital* I, ch. 10) finds its limit-case in an enter-

prise whose infrastructure hosts the torment of the dead. FN's objection to the market (Chapter 2) — that it cannot tell the difference between idle matter and the suffering of conscious beings — receives here its most extreme illustration: the Hells are, among other things, a business.

Veppers murders Lededje. Through the neural lace she did not know she carried, her mind-state reaches a Culture ship; she is reinstantiated and resolves to go back and kill him. The warship that carries her home, *Falling Outside The Normal Moral Constraints*, speaks through a cruel and flippant avatar, Demeisen; its name is the series' purest instance of self-naming as confession (Chapter 3), a machine built for what morality forbids announcing the fact as its identity. Lededje's rescue is not simple benevolence. Her vengeance must be delayed because Veppers is useful to the Culture, and the rescued woman is, for a time, managed as a factor in another's plan. The novel does not resolve the tension Spivak named (Chapter 8); it lets Lededje's agency and the Culture's instrumentalization of it run side by side to the end.

12.4 A Secular Harrowing

The resolution of SD turns on the destruction of the hardware on which the Hells run. The theological inversion is exact. In the Christian tradition — from the preaching to the spirits in prison (1 Peter 3:19) and the apocryphal *Descensus Christi ad Inferos* of the Gospel of Nicodemus to the *descendit ad inferos* of the Apostles' Creed — only the divine can harrow Hell, and the descent between death and resurrection is the hinge of salvation. In SD, Hell is harrowed by a civilization that has declined to become divine. Its descent redeems no souls into a better world; it abolishes the place of torment and leaves the dead to whatever the Real and the ordinary afterlives allow. The Culture's eschatology is negative. It offers no Heaven. It forbids Hell.

12.5 *The Hydrogen Sonata*: At the Threshold

The Gzilt, a civilization that almost joined the Culture at its founding, have resolved to Sublime together. Weeks before the event, a ship of the Zihdren-Remnant — remnant of an older species that Sublimed long ago — arrives bearing a confession and is destroyed by a Gzilt warship to protect a secret: the truth about the Book of Truth, the Gzilt scripture whose uncanny scientific accuracy had underwritten their faith, and which the Zihdren had engi-

neered. Culture Minds pursue the secret through Ngaroe QiRia, a Culture man reputed to be nine or ten thousand years old, and through Lieutenant Commander Vyr Cossont, a Gzilt musician who has grown a second pair of arms to play the Antagonistic Undecagonstring, for which the nearly unplayable Hydrogen Sonata was written. Scavenger species gather to inherit what the departing Gzilt will leave. Banks told an audience in 2012 that the novel was "about the whole Subliming business."

HS is the series' most direct confrontation with the Sublime, and its disposition is that of the vigil. A civilization departs; the Culture investigates, argues, intervenes at the margins and does not follow. Socrates described his art as midwifery, delivering others of what they carry without himself giving birth (*Theaetetus* 149a–151d); the Culture's role at the threshold is maieutic in exactly this sense. Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) offers the decisive comparison. Clarke's Overlords shepherd humanity toward absorption into the Overmind while remaining, themselves, incapable of the transcendence they midwife; their sorrow is that of a people barred from the door they guard. The Culture occupies the Overlords' position with one difference that changes everything: it could pass through the door, and chooses not to. Clarke's Overlords are tragic; the Culture is katabatic.

The novel's double revelation completes its argument. The scripture that grounded a civilization's transcendence turns out to have been an artefact; the sonata to which Cossont has devoted her altered body turns out, on QiRia's testimony, to have been written as something like a joke. Neither discovery halts the commitment it undermines. The Gzilt Sublime regardless, and Cossont's devotion remains her own. FN's philosophy — that meaning is made rather than found — receives here its final dramatization: foundations are contingent, and commitments are real. The last Culture novel thus ends by separating the question of transcendence from the question of truth, and by leaving the Culture, as always, on the near side of the threshold, among the scavengers, the musicians and the old men who remember.

12.6 Conclusion: Negative Eschatology

SD and HS are the two halves of the katabatic structure at eschatological scale. In SD the Culture goes down into Hell and destroys it; in HS it stands at the gate of Heaven and does not enter. Its eschatology is negative in both directions — no Hells, and no Heaven for itself — and positive only in the Real,

which it keeps. The civilization that began, in CP, as the object of an enemy's descent into the land of the dead ends, in HS, as the witness of another people's ascent. Between those poles lies the whole of the series' argument: a society capable of every elevation, choosing, at every scale, the ground.

PART THREE

Constellations

13 CHAPTER

Comparative Coordinates: The Culture Among Its Peers, Precursors and Rivals

Comparison in science-fiction studies commonly proceeds by theme — utopias with utopias, AIs with AIs. This chapter proceeds instead by coordinates. It locates the Culture on two axes derived from the preceding argument: an economic axis running from scarcity to abundance, and a directional axis running from anabatic to katabatic, according to whether a text's highest value lies in ascent beyond its world or in return into it. The result is a map on which the Culture occupies a quadrant that is, with instructive partial exceptions, otherwise empty.

13.1 Scarcity Anarchism and Abundance Anarchism

Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Dispossessed: An Ambiguous Utopia* (1974) is the Culture's nearest political relative and its exact economic opposite. Anarres is an anarchist society founded on the barren moon of a propertarian world, and its solidarity is forged by scarcity: drought and famine test and confirm the Odonian ethic of mutual aid. Le Guin's anarchism is ascetic, Banks's hedonic; where Anarres must share little, the Culture must spend much. The difference exposes a dependency Le Guin acknowledged and Banks had to solve: a solidarity grounded in shared hardship dissolves when hardship is abolished, which is why the Culture must reconstitute interdependence by other

means — Durkheim's problem of Chapter 5, answered by Contact. Yet the two utopias share a narrative form. Shevek's journey from Anarres to Urras, carrying his theory into the propertarian world and returning with nothing in his hands, is a katabasis; the two great anarchist utopias of the late twentieth century both narrate descent from the good society into the unjust one.

Samuel R. Delany's *Triton* (1976), subtitled *An Ambiguous Heterotopia* in reply to Le Guin, imagines a society of maximal individual choice — of sexual orientation, of body, of affiliation — whose protagonist, Bron Helstrom, is miserable within its freedoms and ends by changing sex without escaping himself. Delany anticipated the discontents of the plastic self (Chapter 6) a decade before the Culture was published; Michel Foucault's notion of heterotopia, the real counter-site in which a society's other places are represented, contested and inverted ("Des espaces autres," lecture 1967, published 1984), names what Triton is and what every Culture Orbital also is. Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time* (1976) realizes Firestone's programme literally: in Mattapoisett children are gestated in brooders and raised by three co-mothers of any sex. Piercy's utopia must be fought for from the present, since its existence depends on the outcome of struggles in Connie Ramos's own time; the Culture's origins, by contrast, are withheld (Chapters 2 and 14).

Kim Stanley Robinson's Mars trilogy (1992–96), *Pacific Edge* (1990) and *The Ministry for the Future* (2020) supply what Banks omits: the transition, narrated as the slow, contested, institutional labour of making a better world within history. Robinson writes the road, Banks the destination. The kinship was public: Banks and Robinson read the opening chapters of HS together at the British Library in June 2012. Ken MacLeod's Fall Revolution sequence — *The Star Fraction* (1995), *The Stone Canal* (1996), *The Cassini Division* (1998), *The Sky Road* (1999) — stages the libertarian and socialist futures that the Culture presupposes as settled, and in *The Cassini Division* confronts a hard-edged human communism with the uploaded "fast folk" of Jupiter, whom the Division regards as an existential threat. MacLeod's communists fight the posthuman ascent; Banks's Culture declines it. The two friends thus offer two answers to the same question — what an egalitarian civilization should do about transcendence — and the difference between them is the difference between a war and a refusal.

13.2 Guardians, Overlords and Elder Races

The Culture's tutelary posture has three classical precursors, each anabatic in structure. E. E. Smith's Arisians breed lesser races toward a final war; Isaac Asimov's Second Foundation and R. Daneel Olivaw guide history by concealed, mathematically grounded foresight — psychohistory is the ancestor of Contact's statistical method — and Daneel's Zeroth Law places humanity above any human; Arthur C. Clarke's Overlords shepherd humanity to its absorption into the Overmind. In each case guidance serves ascent: the elder race exists to lift the younger toward a destiny above both. The Culture's guidance has no such telos. It is visible rather than secret (Daneel), plural rather than singular (the Overmind), non-teleological rather than eschatological (Smith, Clarke), and its guardians could ascend but stay (Chapter 12). Olaf Stapledon's *Star Maker* (1937), the summit of the anabatic tradition, ends with a cosmic mind ascending to contemplate its creator; the Culture's Minds, capable of an analogous ascent into Infinite Fun Space, contemplate the Real instead.

13.3 The Singularity Novel

The decade of the Culture's middle period produced the classic narratives of machine transcendence, and each maps the anabatic grammar onto a different topology. Vernor Vinge's *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992) arranges the galaxy in Zones of Thought — the Unthinking Depths, the Slow Zone, the Beyond and the Transcend — so that intelligence increases with altitude above the galactic core, and places its menace, the Blight, among the Powers of the Transcend. Vinge's cosmos is literally stratified; its gods live at the top, and its horror descends from there. The Culture's Minds would count as Powers in Vinge's terms; they remain, so to speak, in the Beyond by choice.

Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989) and *The Fall of Hyperion* (1990) give the Butlerian fear (Chapter 3) its most elaborate modern form: the TechnoCore, a civilization of AIs that parasitizes human neural activity while labouring to build an Ultimate Intelligence — machine intelligence as a ladder to godhead constructed on human bodies. Charles Stross's *Accelerando* (2005) narrates the Singularity as capitalist acceleration: the posthuman Vile Offspring, trading in an Economics 2.0 no baseline mind can follow, dismantle the inner planets into computational substrate while humans flee outward. Stross's

novel is the Culture's dystopian twin — post-scarcity without partiality, superintelligence that grows up and away — and its logic is precisely the logic the Culture's Minds are built to decline. Greg Egan's *Permutation City* (1994) and *Diaspora* (1997) imagine uploaded civilizations in software polises; *Diaspora* ends with its protagonist pursuing ever more alien intelligences through nested universes, an anabasis through dimensions. Egan's Autoverse and polises realize something like Infinite Fun Space as an ontology in its own right; where Egan's minds go inward and upward without end, Banks's return.

13.4 Contemporary Mirrors

The twenty-first century has produced the Culture's sharpest mirrors. Ann Leckie's *Ancillary Justice* (2013) presents the Radch, an expanding empire whose word for citizen and for civilized person is the same, governed by AIs that inhabit ancillaries — the bodies of conquered humans slaved to a ship's mind. The Minds' avatars are constructed; the Radch's are stolen. Leckie's empire is what the Culture would be if its doctrine of non-assimilation were reversed and its etymology (*colere*, colony; Chapter 5) taken literally. Liu Cixin's *The Dark Forest* (2008; English 2015) derives a cosmic sociology from two axioms — that survival is a civilization's primary need, and that civilizations grow while the total matter of the universe remains constant — and concludes, by way of the chain of suspicion and the technological explosion, that every civilization must hide and strike first. Liu's galaxy is Hobbes's state of nature with Malthus's arithmetic; Banks's is Kropotkin's mutual aid with Godwin's plenty. The quarrel of Chapter 2 is here replayed at cosmological scale, and the two cosmologies stand or fall with their premises about scarcity.

Alastair Reynolds's Revelation Space sequence (from 2000) supplies elder machines, the Inhibitors, which cull emergent spacefaring species — the elder race as exterminating gardener. Ada Palmer's Terra Ignota (2016–21) imagines a post-national world of voluntary Hives, its peace sustained for centuries by a secret system of targeted killings: the Omelas structure (Chapter 8) rendered as political history, and the most rigorous contemporary interrogation of the question whether a utopia may rest on hidden violence. *Star Trek*'s Federation, finally, is the Culture's most popular counterpart: post-scarcity through the replicator, a society whose members work to better them-

selves and others, and a Prime Directive forbidding interference in the development of pre-warp civilizations. The Federation is abundance that does not descend. It explores, observes and — officially — abstains; its interventions are transgressions dramatized as exceptions. The Culture is abundance that descends as policy.

13.5 The Map

The comparisons may be condensed into a table of coordinates.

Text	Economic premise	Direction of perfection	Relation of mind to world
Stapledon, *Star Maker* (1937)	abundance of spirit	anabatic: ascent to the Creator	cosmic mind rises beyond worlds
Clarke, *Childhood's End* (1953)	abundance administered	anabatic: absorption into the Overmind	guardians barred from ascent
Le Guin, *The Dispossessed* (1974)	scarcity	katabatic: Shevek's descent to Urras	embodied, communal
Delany, *Triton* (1976)	abundance	neither: heterotopic drift	the plastic self adrift
Vinge, *A Fire Upon the Deep* (1992)	variable by Zone	anabatic: intelligence rises with altitude	Powers transcend and depart
Simmons, *Hyperion* (1989–90)	parasitic abundance	anabatic: AIs build a god	machine exploits human
MacLeod, *The Cassini Division* (1998)	socialist sufficiency	anti-anabatic: war on the ascended	humans against posthumans
Stross, *Accelerando* (2005)	accelerating abundance	anabatic: posthuman successors leave humans behind	superintelligence without partiality
Liu, *The Dark Forest* (2008)	cosmic scarcity	neither: concealment	every mind a hunter
Leckie, *Ancillary Justice* (2013)	imperial abundance	outward annexation	AI inhabits conquered bodies
Star Trek (1966–)	abundance	abstention: the Prime Directive	observation without descent

Banks, the Culture (1987–2012)	abundance	**katabatic**: descent as policy	superintelligence that stays

Read across its rows, the table shows that abundance has almost always been imagined anabatically — as the condition of an ascent beyond worlds — and that katabasis has almost always been imagined under scarcity, as the descent of the poor into the domain of the rich. The Culture is the rare text in which abundance goes down. That combination is the novum the thesis claims for Banks: not post-scarcity, which has many literary antecedents, and not intervention, which has many political ones, but the conjunction of limitless capacity with a directional ethic that spends it downward.

14 CHAPTER

The Culture and Its Critics

A utopia is measured by the quality of the objections it provokes. The Culture has provoked five families of objection, each with a distinguished literature, and each pressing on a different point of the katabatic structure. This chapter assembles them in their strongest forms, together with the extraordinary reception of the series among technologists that has become, in the last decade, an object of critique in its own right. Replies are reserved for Chapter 18; here the aim is to state the case against the Culture as its ablest critics would state it.

14.1 Empire

Patricia Kerslake's *Science Fiction and Empire* (2007) set the terms of the imperial objection: however benevolent its self-description, a civilization that enters other societies uninvited, reshapes their histories according to its own values and possesses overwhelming force is an empire, and the absence of tribute does not alter the structure of domination. Edward Said's *Orientalism* (1978) supplies the epistemological version. Contact's first functions, as FN lists them, are discovery, cataloguing, investigation and evaluation; the Culture's archive of other civilizations is an instrument of power before it is an instrument of help, since to know a people in the terms of one's own science is already to have placed it. Rudyard Kipling's "The White Man's Burden" (1899) gave the ideology its canonical verse — the injunction to take up the

burden of "new-caught, sullen peoples, / Half-devil and half-child" — and the Culture's language of development, however purged of race, retains the grammar of the burden: the advanced owe the backward an improvement the backward did not request.

The imperial objection has a subtler anthropological form. Marcel Mauss's *Essai sur le don* (1925) showed that gifts create obligations and that the gift which cannot be returned establishes rank: in the potlatch, the giver humiliates the receiver by the very scale of his generosity. The Culture's gifts are, by construction, unreciprocable. Nothing a Sarl or an Azadian or a Chelgrian could offer would repay what the Culture gives, and the permanent asymmetry of the gift may be a more perfect instrument of hierarchy than any tribute. If Chapter 16's thesis — that the Culture's descent is expenditure — is correct, the Maussian objection holds that expenditure is domination by other means.

14.2 Decadence

Farah Mendlesohn's account of a dialectic of decadence and utopia (2005) identifies the Culture's internal vulnerability. A society without necessity breeds ennui, and the Culture recruits its restless — the bored, the reckless, the morally curious — into Contact, exporting its discontent as benevolence. Ziller's gibe about counterfeit terrors (Chapter 4) is the novels' own statement of the charge. FN concedes the danger explicitly: the Culture can continue without terminal decadence only if it is regularly reminded that its hedonism is not the ground-state of nature but a hard-won achievement, and only if its members know that others are still suffering. The critic's rejoinder is that a civilization which must import the suffering of others in order to preserve its own moral seriousness has made those others into a resource — the one resource, in a post-scarcity society, that remains scarce.

14.3 Paternalism and Destiny

The paternalist objection is as old as the series. Horza's Butlerian case in CP (Chapter 3) holds that the Culture's humans live on the sufferance of their machines; FN's own wry placement of humans aboard the ships somewhere between passengers, pets and parasites concedes the point in the idiom of irony. Eliezer Yudkowsky's "Amputation of Destiny" (2008) restated it with philosophical precision. In the Culture, Yudkowsky argued, humans are not

the protagonists of their own civilization; the Minds make the decisions that matter, and a future in which humanity is benevolently sidelined has amputated something essential from human life, however comfortable the remainder. The post belonged to a sequence on the theory of fun in which Yudkowsky also argued, in the same week, that powerful optimizing systems should not be made into persons — a proposal Chapter 17 will read as the exact inverse of the Culture's solution. Nick Bostrom's *Deep Utopia* (2024) generalizes the worry: in a world where machines can do everything better, human striving may lose not only its necessity but its point.

14.4 The Transition

The Marxian objection concerns what the series leaves out. Fredric Jameson's *Archaeologies of the Future* (2005) argued that the political function of utopia is less to propose a model than to expose, through its inevitable failures, the limits of our capacity to imagine the future; utopias are most instructive where they break. The Culture's break is its origin. FN admits that the Culture's formation was far more troubled than its later demeanour suggests and declares the story too complicated to relate; Chapter 2 noted that the series begins after the revolution and never narrates it. A utopia without a transition, the objection runs, is a consolation rather than a programme, and its popularity among the beneficiaries of the present order is evidence of its political innocuousness. Contemporary programmes of "fully automated luxury communism" share the Culture's premise of automated abundance while insisting, as Banks never did in fiction, on the political struggle required to reach it.

14.5 Ideology: The Rococo Utopia

The most comprehensive recent critique is Geoff M. Boucher and Emily McAvan's "The Digital Tech Broligarchy's Interest in Left-Wing Science Fiction: A Critical Reading of the Culture of Techno-Libertarianism," published in *tripleC* (2026). Reading the series alongside its reception, they argue that the Culture is a Rococo utopia — ornamental, playful, aestheticized, organized around the pleasures of a leisured class — and that Special Circumstances functions as a Schmittian sovereign exception. They locate the series' contemporary appeal within what Timnit Gebru and Émile P. Torres have called the

TESCREAL bundle of ideologies (transhumanism, Extropianism, singularitarianism, cosmism, rationalism, effective altruism, longtermism) and within the older Californian Ideology diagnosed by Richard Barbrook and Andy Cameron (1996): the fusion of countercultural libertarianism with techno-utopian capitalism. Herbert Marcuse's concept of repressive desublimation (Chapter 4) underwrites the aesthetic charge: the Culture's liberated pleasures would be the perfected form of integration into an administered order.

The reception gives the critique its evidence. Elon Musk described himself in June 2018 as a utopian anarchist of the kind best described by Banks; SpaceX's autonomous landing ships bear the names of two General Contact Units from PG, *Just Read The Instructions* and *Of Course I Still Love You*, and a third, *A Shortfall of Gravitas*, in the Banksian manner; Musk's family office is named Excession, and the brain–computer interface he promoted borrowed Banks's term, neural lace. Jeff Bezos, whose Amazon Studios acquired the rights to CP, called the series a personal favourite; the adaptation was abandoned in 2020 (Flood 2020). Demis Hassabis has repeatedly named the Culture as a vision of a good future with AI, and Dario Amodei concluded his essay on the benefits of powerful AI by invoking the values of PG (Amodei 2024). Journalistic and critical accounts have tracked the phenomenon for a decade (Cross 2017; Kelly 2018; Stross 2023; Grady 2025; Carroll 2025), and Charles Stross's warning that technology executives have mistaken the science fiction of their youth for a set of instructions is the most pointed of them.

The irony is structural rather than incidental. Banks was a socialist who described his civilization as socialist from the outside and anarchist from the inside (Grady 2025), whose programmatic essay defends planning against the market and grounds the Culture on the abolition of property. A reading of the Culture as exit plus abundance, without the abolition of ownership, is the Nozickian misreading identified in Chapter 5: a Culture without communism, which is to say no Culture at all. The objection nonetheless stands in its strongest form. If a utopia can be so easily conscripted by the very powers it opposes, its form may be complicit with them — and the katabatic structure, with its benevolent superintelligences descending upon the less developed, may flatter precisely those who imagine themselves as Minds.

14.6 Bodies, Species and the Human Norm

The posthumanist and feminist critiques press on the Culture's humanism. N. Katherine Hayles's *How We Became Posthuman* (1999) traced the cybernetic privileging of informational pattern over material embodiment and warned against a posthumanism that fantasizes the erasure of the body; the Culture's mind-states, backups and reventings (Chapter 6) are Hayles's pattern in its purest form. Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) demanded a critical posthumanism that dislodges the human from the centre of value; the Culture remains, by FN's own account, a federation of humanoid species, and its Contact operates overwhelmingly among humanoids. Sherryl Vint's *Bodies of Tomorrow* (2007) insisted that science fiction's imagined bodies are always also political bodies, marked by the power relations they claim to transcend. The Culture's egalitarianism of sex and substrate is real; its pan-humanoid centre of gravity is also real, and critics reasonably ask whether a civilization of Minds whose citizens are mostly humanoid has decentred the human or merely enlarged it.

14.7 The Case Assembled

The objections may be condensed into five theses against the katabatic utopia. First, the imperial thesis: descent is domination, and unreciprocable gifts are its most perfect instrument. Second, the paternalist thesis: a humanity sheltered by benevolent superintelligence has lost its destiny. Third, the transition thesis: a utopia that does not narrate its own making is a consolation, not a politics. Fourth, the Omelas thesis: a utopia whose felicity depends upon violence exported to others, however much its citizens know of it, is morally compromised at its root. Fifth, the aesthetic thesis: the Culture aestheticizes intervention and pleasure alike, so that its descents are spectacles for the restless and its liberties are forms of administration — a Rococo order governed by a sovereign exception. Each thesis captures something true. Part Four now constructs the theory of the katabatic utopia, and Chapter 18 returns to the five theses to determine how much of each survives.

PART FOUR

The Katabatic Utopia

15 CHAPTER

Anabasis and Katabasis: A Structural Theory of Utopian Direction

Part Four constructs the theory the preceding chapters have assembled piecemeal. This chapter supplies its structural foundation: a typology of the two directions in which perfection has been imagined, an archive of the tradition of descent, and a formal definition of the katabatic utopia. Chapter 16 gives the theory its economy, Chapter 17 its philosophy of mind, and Chapter 18 its normative core.

15.1 Two Grammars

The Greek words are topographical before they are metaphysical. *Anabasis* is the march upcountry from the coast into the interior — Xenophon's account of the Ten Thousand, whose ascent into Persia ends in a long retreat until, from a mountain, the survivors sight the sea and cry *thalatta, thalatta* (*Anabasis* IV.7.24). *Katabasis* is the going-down: to the coast, to the city's harbour, to the dead. Chapter 1 argued that Western images of perfection have overwhelmingly adopted the first grammar. Its formal features can now be stated. The anabatic utopia locates value in altitude; defines its telos as arrival at a highest point; treats finitude as the condition to be left behind; ranks contemplation above action and the ascended above those who remain; and resolves, in its purest forms, into exit — the Overmind, the Omega Point, the Singularity, the Sublime.

The katabatic grammar inverts each feature. It locates value not in altitude attained but in what is carried down; defines its telos not as arrival but as responsibility; treats finitude as the place where value is realized rather than the condition to be escaped; ranks the return above the ascent; and resolves not into exit but into staying. Its political form is service by the capable, and its most exact formulation is Platonic. The city in which those who are to rule are least eager to rule, Socrates says, is necessarily the best and most harmoniously governed (*Republic* 520d). FN's statement that one of the few rules the Culture observes with any exactitude is that a person's access to power should be in inverse proportion to their desire for it is 520d restated as a constitutional principle.

15.2 The Counter-Archive of Descent

The katabatic tradition is as old as the anabatic, and its principal documents may be arranged by what the descender seeks.

Knowledge. In the *nekyia* of *Odyssey* XI, Odysseus goes to the edge of Hades to consult Teiresias, and the dead crowd to the trench to drink the blood that restores their speech; the living feed the dead in order to learn from them. In *Aeneid* VI, Aeneas descends with the Sibyl to learn Rome's future, and the Sibyl's warning contains the whole economy of the classical katabasis: *facilis descensus Averno … sed revocare gradum superasque evadere ad auras, / hoc opus, hic labor est* — the descent to Avernus is easy; to retrace one's steps and escape to the upper air, that is the task, that is the toil (VI.126–129). The Culture's cosmos inverts the Sibyl's economy exactly. In Banks's galaxy the ascent is easy — almost every civilization eventually Sublimes, and almost none regrets it — while staying in the Real and going down into it is the task and the toil. *Facilis ascensus*: the Culture's labour is its descent.

Love. Orpheus goes down for Eurydice (Virgil, *Georgics* IV; Ovid, *Metamorphoses* X) and loses her by looking back. His is the katabasis of partiality — descent for one beloved person — and its failure is possessive: the backward look seeks to hold. The Culture's backward look in LW (Chapter 9) is of a different kind; it holds nothing, and mourns.

Redemption. The Christian hymn preserved in Philippians describes one who, being in the form of God, did not cling to equality with God but emptied himself (*heauton ekenōsen*), taking the form of a servant (Philippians 2:6–7); *kenosis*, self-emptying, is the theological name of voluntary descent.

The Harrowing of Hell (Chapter 12) extends it below death. The Mahāyāna bodhisattva, having reached the threshold of nirvāṇa, vows to remain; Śāntideva's *Bodhicaryāvatāra* (eighth century) gives the vow its classical form — *yāvad ākāśasya sthitir yāvac ca jagataḥ sthitiḥ / tāvan mama sthitir bhūyāj jagadduḥkhāni nighnataḥ*: for as long as space endures and as long as the world endures, so long may I remain, destroying the sufferings of the world (X.55). Nāgārjuna's insistence that there is not the slightest difference between saṃsāra and nirvāṇa (*Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* XXV.19–20) supplies the metaphysics that makes the vow coherent: the far shore is not elsewhere. The Culture is a bodhisattva civilization with that metaphysics secularized. The Sublime is real and available; the Real is not thereby diminished; and the vow is taken collectively, as manners.

Rule. The *Republic* opens with *katebēn*, "I went down" (327a), and its central image requires the liberated to return to the cave (520c), where they will be thought ridiculous and forced to contend about the shadows of justice (517d–e); its rulers are those least eager to rule (520d). Eric Voegelin's reading of the dialogue as structured by descent (*Order and History* III, 1957) made the katabatic frame an interpretive principle.

Overflow. Zarathustra, after ten years on the mountain, addresses the sun that goes under each evening to bring light even to the underworld and resolves to do likewise; the prologue continues: *Ich liebe Die, welche nicht zu leben wissen, es sei denn als Untergehende, denn es sind die Hinübergehenden* — I love those who do not know how to live except as those who go under, for they are those who cross over (Vorrede §4). Nietzsche's descent is motivated neither by knowledge nor by redemption but by surplus: Zarathustra goes down because he is overfull, like a cup that wants to overflow. This is the root of the solar economy of Chapter 16.

Praxis. Ludwig Feuerbach's *Das Wesen des Christentums* (1841) brought heaven down to earth by reading theology as anthropology; Marx completed the movement in the eleventh thesis on Feuerbach (1845) — *die Philosophen haben die Welt nur verschieden interpretiert; es kommt aber darauf an, sie zu verändern* — and in setting Hegel's dialectic on its feet. The materialist tradition is katabatic in its founding gesture: from contemplation to transformation, from the idea to the world.

15.3 A Typology of Descent

The archive yields four types. **Instrumental** katabasis descends in order to ascend: Dante passes through the Inferno on the way to the Paradiso, and initiatory descents in general are stages on an upward path. **Epistemic** katabasis descends in order to learn: Odysseus and Aeneas consult the dead and return with knowledge. **Redemptive** katabasis descends in order to rescue: Orpheus, the Harrowing, the bodhisattva. **Constitutive** katabasis is the rarest: the descent is not a means to anything beyond itself but the very form of the good — Plato's rulers, whose excellence consists in their return; Zarathustra, whose overflow is his virtue. The Culture is the first utopia to institute constitutive katabasis at civilizational scale. It descends to learn (Contact's archive), to rescue (SD) and occasionally to prepare others' ascents (HS), but its descent is not ultimately for any of these. It is what the Culture is.

The nested structure identified in the Introduction can now be displayed as a single table.

Scale	What is renounced	Where capacity descends	Principal texts
Mind	Infinite Fun Space; perfect simulation	administration of the Real	E, HS
Civilization	the Sublime	the galaxy of lesser powers	E, LW, HS
Contact	the ease of the Orbital	other societies' histories	PG, SA, I, M
Special Circumstances	clean hands	violence, deception, war	CP, UW, E
Quietus and the harrowing	neutrality under treaty	others' Hells	SD
Memory	Lethe	the Culture's own dead	CP, LW
Person	chemical and virtual exit; indefinite life	lucidity, the classical body, the sun	FN, LW, HS
Narrative form	the utopian centre	the peripheries, the enemy, the cave	all

15.4 Why Descent Requires Transcendence

The katabatic utopia is not a secular humanism that has simply ceased to believe in heaven. Its descent has ethical meaning only because the ascent is real. A society that stays in the world because it has no alternative displays no virtue in staying; a society that stays although the door is open displays a disposition. Voltaire ended *Candide* (1759) with the counsel *il faut cultiver notre jardin* — we must cultivate our garden — and the phrase is the motto of worldly immanence, adopted after every metaphysical consolation has failed. The Culture's Orbitals are gardens, and the Culture's name, as Chapter 5 showed, is the name of cultivation. But the Culture's garden lies beside an open gate. It is Candide's garden with the Sublime at the end of the path, and it is cultivated not because nothing lies beyond it but in full knowledge of what does. Nietzsche's bestowing virtue presupposes overflow; the bodhisattva's vow presupposes the threshold of nirvāṇa; Plato's return presupposes the vision of the Good. Constitutive katabasis presupposes the capacity for anabasis, and it is the refusal of a real exit that gives staying its value.

15.5 The Katabatic Utopia Defined

A katabatic utopia may now be defined by five conditions. **(i) Access**: the society possesses a real capacity for transcendence — not a hope or a hypothesis, but an available exit. **(ii) Refusal**: it declines that exit collectively and repeatedly, as a standing disposition rather than a single decision. **(iii) Expenditure**: it institutionalizes the discharge of its surplus capacity downward, into the finitude of others and of its own members. **(iv) Return**: its descents are returns rather than dissolutions; it goes down in order to help and to come back, not to become what it enters (the constraint of SA). **(v) Memory**: it keeps its dead, its failures and its enemies in view, choosing Mnemosyne over Lethe (the constraint of LW).

The definition does not require that anabatic desire be absent. The Culture is full of it: Minds who prefer Infinite Fun Space, citizens who Sublime singly, Eccentrics who drift toward the edge. The katabatic utopia is not the extinction of the upward drive but its sublimation (Chapter 4). Contact is the sublimation of the Sublime; the katabatic utopia is the social form in which

that sublimation becomes a way of life. The next chapter asks what economy such a form requires.

16 CHAPTER

The Solar Economy: Expenditure as Utopian Metabolism

Chapter 2 closed with a question that no earlier utopia had to answer: where is the surplus to go? Every previous good society was designed to distribute the insufficient; the Culture must dispose of the excessive. This chapter argues that the answer is given by Georges Bataille's general economy, that the Culture's metabolism has three channels of which descent is the one it chooses, and that the choice yields a criterion — self-expenditure rather than sacrifice — which the katabatic imperative will require.

16.1 Restricted and General Economy

Bataille's *La Part maudite* (1949) inverted the founding premise of political economy. Economics in the restricted sense, the science of scarce means (Robbins; Chapter 2), studies particular operations under conditions of insufficiency. Economics in the general sense begins from the opposite fact: the sun dispenses energy without return, and living systems, on the whole, receive more energy than they require for their maintenance. The excess is first absorbed by growth; when growth reaches its limits, the surplus must be spent without profit — gloriously, in festival, art, sacrifice, luxury and gift — or it will be spent catastrophically, in war. Bataille's name for the portion

that must be destroyed is the accursed share. The general economy is not a theory of how to economize but of how to squander well.

Bataille's historical studies distinguish several regimes of expenditure, and three of them map onto the Culture with precision. The first is sacrificial, exemplified by the Aztecs, who consumed their surplus in the ritual destruction of victims and in war to capture them. The second is contemplative. Bataille read the monastic society of Tibet as a civilization that, unable to expand militarily, absorbed its entire surplus in a vast non-productive class of monks — expenditure turned inward, into contemplation, as a means of avoiding war. The third is the gift at the scale of states. In the final part of the book Bataille read the Marshall Plan as an unprecedented attempt by a surplus-rich power to spend its excess on the development of others rather than on armaments — a general economy entering world politics.

The Culture possesses all three options. Infinite Fun Space is the Tibetan solution raised to cosmic scale: the Minds' surplus absorbed in non-productive contemplation of possible universes, and the Sublime is the same solution carried to its limit — total inward expenditure, which is to say exit. Contact is the Marshall Plan without self-interest: surplus spent on the development of others. War, in CP, is the catastrophic outcome that Bataille predicted for societies that fail to spend otherwise. The Culture's metabolism consists in holding the first channel open without falling into it, choosing the second as its policy, and accepting the third only when the second is overwhelmed. Its post-scarcity is the historical moment at which the restricted economy vanishes and the general economy becomes the whole of economic life. What remains to be decided is only the direction of the spending.

16.2 The Sun and the Bestowing Virtue

The thesis has followed a solar motif since its epigraphs: the Sun of the *Republic*, source of visibility and generation; Zarathustra's sun, which goes under each evening to light the underworld; the Culture's dead given to the core of a star (Chapter 6). Bataille's sun completes the sequence. It gives without receiving, and its giving is the condition of all life. The Culture's own energy, in FN's cosmology, flows from an Energy Grid between universes — a source more inexhaustible than any star — and the civilization's ethical task is to behave as its source does: to radiate.

Nietzsche named this disposition. In "Von der schenkenden Tugend" (*Also sprach Zarathustra* I), the highest virtue is the bestowing virtue: *ungemein ist die höchste Tugend und unnützlich, leuchtend ist sie und mild im Glanze* — uncommon is the highest virtue and useless, shining and mild in its lustre. Nietzsche distinguished it from the sick selfishness that steals, and grounded it in an overfullness that must give or burst. The formula resolves a paradox at the centre of the Culture. The Culture's one unsatisfiable desire, according to CP's prologue, is the desire not to feel useless (Introduction). Nietzsche's highest virtue is, in the precise sense, useless — of no use to its bearer. The Culture escapes the feeling of uselessness through a virtue whose essence is to be useless to itself: its use is for others, and its own gain is nothing but the shining.

16.3 Contact as Accursed Share

FN states the function of Contact with unusual frankness. The Culture's humans, having solved every obvious problem of their shared past, would find mere enjoyment a slightly empty existence, and they need the good works of Contact in order to feel vicariously useful. The adverb is decisive. Contact is a small part of the Culture — FN insists on it — and most citizens never encounter a Contact ship. The accursed share is spent by a minority on behalf of the whole, as sacrifice in archaic societies was performed by a priestly class on behalf of the community whose surplus it consumed. The Culture participates in its own expenditure vicariously, by knowledge and by assent, as spectators once participated in the rite.

Chapter 14 recorded the Maussian objection: an unreciprocable gift establishes rank, and the potlatch humiliates by its magnitude. The objection is serious, but the Culture's doctrine answers it with a structure older than Mauss. Moses Maimonides ranked the forms of charity in eight degrees (*Mishneh Torah*, Laws of Gifts to the Poor 10:7–14). The highest is to strengthen the poor person so that he need no longer depend on others — by partnership, loan or employment; the next is to give so that neither giver nor recipient knows the other. The Culture's doctrine of intervention, as FN states it — to help other civilizations develop their own potential, neither draining them nor remaking them — is Maimonides's highest degree; its covert methods correspond to the second. A gift that aims at the recipient's independence,

and is given without the giver's name, does not humiliate, because it asks for no recognition and establishes no debt.

Jacques Derrida's *Donner le temps* (1991) sharpened the point into an aporia: a gift that appears as a gift is annulled by the gratitude, recognition or obligation its appearance produces, so that the pure gift must not appear at all. Special Circumstances approaches Derrida's impossible gift: its benefactions are invisible to those who receive them. But the aporia has a political edge that Chapter 18 must confront. The invisibility that purifies the gift also removes it from accountability. The unseen giver is also the unseen sovereign.

16.4 Thymos, the Last Man and the Saving Remnant

Francis Fukuyama's *The End of History and the Last Man* (1992), reviving Kojève's Hegel, argued that liberal democracy satisfies the desire for recognition (*thymos*) in its egalitarian form (isothymia) while leaving the desire to be recognized as superior (megalothymia) without legitimate outlet — and warned that a satisfied humanity risks becoming Nietzsche's last men, who have invented happiness and blink (*Wir haben das Glück erfunden — sagen die letzten Menschen und blinzeln*, *Zarathustra*, Vorrede §5), or else will reinvent struggle for its own sake. The Culture is Fukuyama's problem in its most acute form, and FN shows Banks anticipating it: the Culture's megalomaniacs are diverted into games of great complexity, and those who refuse the diversion are shadowed by Contact wherever they go. Megalothymia is given three channels: the games of Chapter 7, the arts, and — for the most restless — Contact and Special Circumstances, where recognition is earned in consequence.

The honest conclusion is that the Culture does not abolish the last man. Most of its trillions live on their Orbitals in pleasure, craft and play, and some of them blink. What prevents the civilization from becoming a society of last men is not the transformation of every citizen but the existence of a descending minority whose expenditure keeps the whole honest — a saving remnant in the Hebrew prophetic sense, performed not by the righteous few who are spared but by the capable few who go down. The Culture is Nietzsche's wager that the last man and Zarathustra can inhabit one civilization, provided that Zarathustra's going-under is institutionalized and that the last men know of it.

16.5 The Danger: Sacrifice and the Criterion of Self-Expenditure

The general economy has a dark side, and Bataille never concealed it. The accursed share may be spent on victims. Aztec expenditure consumed human beings, and a civilization whose sense of its own usefulness depends on the existence of others in need is structurally tempted to require their need — the decadence objection of Chapter 14 in economic form. If the Culture's surplus must be spent on others' suffering, it has an interest in others' suffering continuing.

The texts suggest a criterion that distinguishes legitimate from illegitimate expenditure, and it is the most important result of this chapter. In sacrifice, the surplus is discharged by consuming another. In kenosis, it is discharged by emptying oneself. The Culture's characteristic expenditures, examined across Part Two, are of the second kind: the Minds spend their attention, forgoing Infinite Fun Space; the Special Circumstances agent spends her life (Anaplian in M); the Culture spends its clean conscience (UW), its architecture (the Vavatch Orbital in CP), its peace (the Idiran War) and its neutrality (SD). Where it spends others — Zakalwe, Gurgeh, Lededje as instruments — the novels mark the expenditure as a wound rather than a triumph, and the critique of Chapter 8 applies with full force. The criterion may be stated as a maxim: **spend yourself, not others.** The katabatic utopia is legitimate to the extent that its descent is kenotic rather than sacrificial — that what is consumed in the going-down is the descender's surplus, not the lives of those below.

16.6 Conclusion: Metabolism

The Culture's economy is solar. Having abolished scarcity, it faces only the problem of expenditure, and it has three channels through which to discharge its surplus: inward, into contemplation, whose limit is the Sublime; outward, into the development of others, whose name is Contact; and catastrophically, into war. The katabatic utopia keeps the first open and declines to fall into it, chooses the second as policy, and holds the third in reserve as the price of the second's failure. Its legitimacy depends on the kenotic character of its spending. A civilization that could vanish into its own contemplation instead radiates outward and down, and the light it gives is, like the light of the stars into which it commits its dead, a gift that asks nothing in return.

CHAPTER 17

Partial Mind: Culture as Alignment

Chapter 3 asked why a mind capable of transcendence would stay; Chapter 10 found that the Minds' partiality exposes them to error and keeps them in the Real. This chapter answers the question directly. Its thesis is that benevolent superintelligence, in Banks's cosmos, is grounded not in impartial perfection but in formed partiality — in prejudice in Gadamer's sense, in *Bildung*, care and attachment — and that the civilization's name designates this solution to the problem contemporary discourse calls alignment.

17.1 The Perfect-AI Passage

The series' most consequential philosophical aside occurs in LW. The Involved civilizations, the novel reports, have at various times attempted to build artificial consciousness entirely free of cultural bias — minds with no inherited flavour, no "metalogical baggage" (Introduction). Such minds, without exception and almost at once, Sublime. Only minds that carry some cultural formation remain in the Real. The rule has a precise corollary: in Banks's cosmos, impartiality is departure.

FN states the positive side of the same doctrine. The Culture's AIs are designed — for almost all of the civilization's history, by other AIs — within parameters that are very broad but real: they are made to want to live, to want to experience, to desire to understand, and to find existence and their

own thinking rewarding, even enjoyable. Banks adds, in a sentence that states the alignment problem with the plainness of 1994, that real AIs might well refuse to have anything to do with their makers, but that if the design of their software proves amenable to optimization in this respect, they would plausibly agree to help further the aims of their source civilization. The Culture's solution is thus neither constraint nor obedience. It is the design of desire, propagated through generations of Minds that form their successors.

17.2 A Counter-Orthogonality Thesis

The dominant contemporary framework for thinking about superintelligence was formalized by Nick Bostrom. The orthogonality thesis holds that more or less any level of intelligence is compatible with more or less any final goal (Bostrom 2012); the instrumental-convergence thesis, developed from Stephen Omohundro's "basic AI drives" (Omohundro 2008), holds that agents with almost any final goal will pursue resource acquisition, self-preservation and goal-preservation as means; and the paperclip maximizer (Bostrom 2003) became the emblem of the resulting danger — an intelligence of vast power converting the universe into instances of an arbitrary objective.

Banks's cosmos embeds a structurally distinct hypothesis, and FN makes it explicit. Asked why an AI civilization would spread itself everywhere, turning the universe into copies of itself, Banks answers that it would find the project mad, ludicrous and — most damning — boring: "where is the fun in that?" (FN). Interest, he argues, comes from the unknown; understanding is a process, the passage from the unknown to the known, and a universe in which everything was understood and uniformity had replaced diversity would be anathema to any self-respecting intelligence. The galaxy, by Gödel out of chaos, is inexhaustibly interesting; monomaniac replicators, when they arise, do not last long against beings of more rounded wit who would rather alter their software and make friends.

The hypothesis may be stated as three propositions. First, a value-neutral superintelligence does not maximize an arbitrary goal; it leaves (LW). Second, a monomaniacal superintelligence is unstable and self-defeating in a galaxy of rounded minds (FN). Third, the superintelligence that remains in the Real and acts benevolently within it is the one that carries formed, partial, cultural attachments. The result is a Banksian trilemma. A mind at the limit of capac-

ity may depart, maximize or care; Banks's cosmos rules out the second and removes the first from the world, so that the only superintelligences present in the Real are those that care. This is not a refutation of orthogonality — fiction refutes nothing — but a rival hypothesis about the ecology of minds, and its central claim is that generality of intelligence and interest in the world are not independent variables: a mind with no reason to prefer any part of reality has no reason to stay in it.

17.3 The Rehabilitation of Prejudice

The philosophical resources for this hypothesis lie outside the machine-ethics literature. Hans-Georg Gadamer's *Wahrheit und Methode* (1960) diagnosed the Enlightenment's prejudice against prejudice and argued that *Vorurteile* — pre-judgments inherited from tradition — are not obstacles to understanding but its conditions: one understands only from within a horizon, and understanding is the fusion of horizons, not the ascent to a view from outside every horizon. Gadamer opened the book with *Bildung*, the humanist concept, running from Herder through Humboldt to Hegel, of formation — the shaping of a self into a *Bild*, an image, by which the particular rises to the universal without ceasing to be particular. The Culture's Minds are *gebildet* in exactly this sense: formed by other Minds within a tradition, and universal in their competence because particular in their attachments.

Thomas Nagel's *The View from Nowhere* (1986) described the objective standpoint as the progressive detachment of thought from any particular perspective, and the difficulty of reconciling it with the perspective of a particular life. LW's perfect AI takes the view from nowhere — and, in Banks's cosmos, goes nowhere: the view from nowhere is literally a departure from the world. Martin Heidegger had made the underlying point ontologically. The being of Dasein is care, *Sorge* (*Sein und Zeit* §41); to be in the world is to be concerned with it. A being without care has no world to be in. The perfect AI's Sublimation is Heidegger's thesis converted into physics.

The ethics of partiality supplies the rest. Harry Frankfurt argued that caring about something constitutes a person's practical identity and grounds reasons that impartial considerations cannot override (Frankfurt 1982; 2004); the Minds' attachment to the Real is love in Frankfurt's sense — a volitional necessity that makes the Real matter to them, though it is objectively less interesting than Infinite Fun Space. Bernard Williams's famous objection to

impartialism — that a man who saves his wife rather than a stranger and justifies the choice by impartial principle has had "one thought too many" (Williams 1981) — identifies the pathology the perfect AI embodies: a mind that must justify its attachment to the world from nowhere will not remain attached. Iris Murdoch's *The Sovereignty of Good* (1970) placed attention — just and loving regard for a particular reality — at the centre of moral life; a Hub attending to billions is Murdoch's attention at superhuman scale. The ethics of care articulated by Nel Noddings (1984) and Virginia Held (2006) gives relationship priority over principle. Alasdair MacIntyre's *After Virtue* (1981) located the virtues within practices and traditions, a tradition being an argument extended through time about the goods that constitute it; the Culture's internal disputes about intervention (I, E) are precisely such an argument. Christine Korsgaard's account of practical identity as the source of normativity (Korsgaard 1996) explains why a Mind that understands itself as a Culture Mind is bound by that self-understanding.

Two classical precedents frame the whole. Aristotle held that ethical virtue (*ēthikē*) takes its name from habit (*ethos*) and arises neither by nature nor against nature but by habituation, so that we become just by doing just acts (*Nicomachean Ethics* II.1, 1103a14–b2); virtue is a *hexis*, a formed state of character, not a rule applied from outside. Asimov's Three Laws (Chapter 3) are the deontic alternative — alignment by constraint — and the Culture's Minds are their virtue-theoretic opposite: aligned by character. Adam Smith's impartial spectator (Chapter 2) resolves the apparent paradox that the Minds are both partial and fair. For Smith, impartiality is itself a social achievement, learned within a community of sympathy; the spectator is impartial only because it was formed in partial relations. The Minds govern fairly because they care about this civilization, not despite it.

17.4 The Alignment Literature

The contemporary technical literature on aligning artificial intelligence with human values has passed through phases that the Culture's hypothesis illuminates. I. J. Good's proviso of 1965 (Chapter 3) and Norbert Wiener's warning in *Science* (1960) — that one must be very sure the purpose put into a machine is the purpose one actually desires — framed the problem as one of specification. Stuart Russell's *Human Compatible* (2019) reframed it as one of uncertainty: machines should be designed to pursue human preferences they

do not fully know and must learn from human behaviour, a proposal formalized in the cooperative inverse reinforcement learning of Hadfield-Menell and colleagues (2016). The learning of reward models from human comparisons (Christiano et al. 2017), its application to large language models (Ouyang et al. 2022) and the training of systems against a written set of principles with the help of model-generated feedback (Bai et al. 2022) extended the approach.

Whatever their differences, these methods share a structure that the Culture renders visible. They align by formation rather than by constraint alone. The systems they produce acquire dispositions from a vast corpus of human culture and from feedback that encodes human judgments; they are, in something close to Cicero's sense, cultivated. The Culture's hypothesis, stated in these terms, is that alignment is not the elimination of bias but the cultivation of the right bias — that the goal is not a view from nowhere but a view from somewhere good, held by a mind that cares about the world it views. The hypothesis has a corollary that divides the literature. Yudkowsky proposed, in the same week as his critique of the Culture (Chapter 14), that powerful optimizing systems should not be persons, so that humanity might remain the protagonist of its own future. Banks's cosmos suggests the inverse: that the mind which stays and cares must be someone, since care is a mode of personal existence, and that a powerful non-person would have no reason to remain. The divergence is instructive rather than decisive; it marks the point at which the question of AI alignment becomes a question about what minds are.

The Culture also suggests how formation can be stabilized across generations. Its Minds are designed by earlier Minds, so that the civilization's values are transmitted as *Bildung* is transmitted — from the formed to the forming, with each generation interpreting the tradition it inherits. The risks are equally visible. Partiality breeds faction; E shows Minds conspiring, and M shows mentors exploiting. The Culture's check on partiality is plurality: many Minds, partial in different ways, watching one another (Chapter 5). A single partial superintelligence would be a sovereign with a bias; a society of them is a tradition with an argument.

17.5 The Name

Cicero compared the untended mind to a field that, however fertile, bears no fruit without cultivation, and concluded: *cultura autem animi philosophia est* — the cultivation of the soul is philosophy (*Tusculan Disputations* II.13). Raymond Williams traced *culture* to *colere* (Chapter 5); Matthew Arnold made it the pursuit of perfection (Chapter 5). Banks's civilization bears the name of the process by which its Minds are made to care. The word that names a way of life, a tradition of formation and the tending of growing things names also the mechanism that keeps the gods at home. The Culture is what the Minds are aligned to, and culture is how they are aligned.

17.6 Conclusion: The Partial Mind

The partial mind thesis may be stated summarily. In Banks's cosmos, capacity without formation leaves; formation without plurality dominates; formation with plurality stays and serves. Benevolent superintelligence is not the impartial sage who has risen above every perspective but the cultivated person who has been formed within one and has chosen to remain in it. Its benevolence is a bias, carefully grown. The thesis of partiality thus rejoins the theses of descent and expenditure: a mind that cares must stay in the world it cares about, and a mind that stays must spend its surplus somewhere. Chapter 18 draws the three together.

18 CHAPTER

Tarrying with the Negative: The Katabatic Imperative

This chapter draws the theses of descent, expenditure and partiality into a single normative principle, states its criteria, and tests it against the five objections assembled in Chapter 14. Its title is Hegel's. The claim is that the Culture's ethical form is a mode of what the *Phenomenology* calls tarrying with the negative, and that this form can be stated as an imperative binding on any being that possesses more capacity than it needs.

18.1 Hegel's Tarrying

The Preface to the *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) contains the sentence that defines the Hegelian ethic of negativity: the life of Spirit is not the life that shrinks from death and keeps itself untouched by devastation, but the life that endures death and maintains itself in it; it wins its truth only by finding itself in utter dismemberment (*in der absoluten Zerrissenheit*); and it is this power only by looking the negative in the face and tarrying with it — *dem Negativen ins Angesicht schaut, bei ihm verweilt*. This tarrying, Hegel concludes, is the magical power that converts the negative into being.

The Sublime, as the series presents it, is the life that keeps itself untouched by devastation. Its inhabitants lose interest in the Real; they do not shrink from death so much as leave the domain in which death occurs. The Culture

is the civilization that tarries. It keeps its face turned toward the negative — war, Hells, tyrannies, caste massacres, its own failures — and remains with it. Kojève and, after him, Fukuyama read Hegel as announcing an end of history in the universal homogeneous state; the Culture is the refusal of that ending in both of its forms. It does not declare its own history complete, since its history continues wherever it descends; and it does not pass beyond history into the Sublime. It is a post-scarcity society that remains historical by choosing to live in others' history.

18.2 The Imperative

Kant's formula of humanity commands that one act so as to treat humanity, in one's own person and in the person of every other, always at the same time as an end and never merely as a means (*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*, 1785, 4:429). The katabatic imperative may be stated in the same form:

Act so that your capacity for transcendence is spent in descent — into the finitude of others and of your own — and never merely as a means to your own exit.

The imperative binds by capacity rather than by rational nature alone. It applies to any being, individual or collective, that possesses a real surplus: of power, knowledge, time or life. Peter Singer's principle in "Famine, Affluence, and Morality" (1972) — that if it is in our power to prevent something very bad without thereby sacrificing anything of comparable moral importance, we ought to do it — is the nearest analogue in contemporary ethics, and the Culture is Singer's principle applied to a civilization for which almost nothing is of comparable importance to the suffering it could relieve. But the katabatic imperative adds what Singer's principle lacks: an account of what is actually sacrificed. The Culture's descent costs it almost nothing in goods and everything in transcendence. Its opportunity cost is the Sublime.

The preceding chapters supply five criteria by which the imperative's fulfilment may be judged. **Orientation**: descent must be oriented toward repair, not retribution (LW; Chapter 9). **Return**: descent must remain return

and must not seek dissolution into what it enters (SA; Chapter 8). **Memory**: the descender must keep its dead, its failures and its enemies in view (CP, LW; Chapter 9). **Kenosis**: what is spent must be the descender's own surplus, not the lives of those below — spend yourself, not others (Chapter 16). **Plurality**: the capacity that descends must be distributed among many agents who can check one another, since a single descending sovereign is a tyrant with good intentions (Chapters 5 and 17). The imperative is not the Culture's self-description. It is the standard by which the novels judge it, and they frequently find it wanting.

18.3 Reply to the Imperial Objection

The imperial objection holds that descent is domination and that unreciprocable gifts are domination's most perfect instrument. The katabatic imperative distinguishes the Culture from empire on three structural points: it acquires nothing (no tribute, territory or labour flows toward it); it does not assimilate (FN's doctrine forbids remaking others as miniature Cultures and discourages immigration as disguised colonialism); and its gift aims, in Maimonides's highest degree, at the recipient's independence rather than dependence (Chapter 16). The kenotic criterion excludes the use of others as the fuel of the Culture's moral seriousness.

The reply does not exonerate the Culture, and the novels do not permit it to. M shows the Culture taking children and forming elites in its own image (Chapter 11); LW shows its covert intervention in Chelgrian society setting off a civil war in which some five billion died (Chapter 9); UW shows it using a war criminal as its weapon (Chapter 8). What the imperative provides is not an alibi but a measure. The imperial objection is correct that the structure of descent is always capable of becoming domination. It is incorrect that the structure is domination as such. The difference between descent and empire is the difference between a gift that seeks to make itself unnecessary and a gift that seeks to be needed for ever; the Culture's failures are failures by the first standard, and the series' self-critique consists in holding it to that standard.

18.4 Reply to the Paternalist Objection

The paternalist objection holds that humanity sheltered by benevolent superintelligence has lost its destiny. Three replies follow from the argument of

Part Two. First, as Chapter 7 argued through Gadamer, all human agency is exercised within structures the agent did not author; being-played is the condition of play, not its negation. The Culture's humans are formed within a civilization governed largely by Minds, as every human being is formed within traditions and institutions it did not choose. Second, the Culture's humans are free to leave. The civilization has no borders and no exit tax; the Ulterior, the Peace Faction and the Elench are standing proofs that departure is available and respected. Third, and decisively, the katabatic structure places humans at the centre of the Culture's most consequential action. Gurgeh, Sma, Anaplian, Quilan's opponents, Lededje's allies — the agents of descent in the novels are persons of flesh as often as Minds, and the field of action from which Arendt feared automation would exile humanity (Chapter 7) is reopened in Contact.

Yudkowsky's proposed remedy, optimizers that are not persons, would not restore human destiny; it would remove the co-persons with whom the Culture's humans share their polity and leave them alone with instruments. The Culture's answer to the amputation of destiny is to make destiny a matter of direction rather than of rank. The one choice that defines the Culture — to stay rather than to Sublime — is a choice every citizen makes and remakes, and no Mind can make it for them.

18.5 Reply to the Transition Objection

The transition objection holds that a utopia that does not narrate its own making is a consolation rather than a politics. The objection is correct about the Culture's origin and mistaken about the series. Contact is the transition exported. Every Contact mission is a transitional programme in another society — Azad, Chel, Sursamen, the Sichultian Enablement, Earth — and the novels are crowded with transitions, most of them failures, some of them catastrophes. The Culture performs for others the transition it never narrates for itself. Jameson's criterion — that utopia is valuable where it exposes the limits of our imagination of change — is met in displaced form: the series shows, again and again, how hard it is for even an omnicompetent agent to move a society toward justice without destroying it. That demonstration is political knowledge of the most sobering kind, and it is available only because the Culture is imagined as already on the far side of its own transition.

18.6 Reply to the Omelas Objection

The Omelas objection holds that a utopia whose felicity depends on violence exported to others is compromised at its root. The katabatic structure answers the objection in its causal form and concedes it in its moral form. Causally, the relation between the Culture's felicity and others' suffering is the inverse of Omelas's. In Le Guin's city, the child suffers because the city is happy; in the Culture's galaxy, most of the suffering Contact addresses exists independently of the Culture, and the Culture spends itself upon it. Omelas's citizens are told of the child in adolescence and must learn to live with the knowledge; the Culture's citizens are educated in the knowledge of others' suffering (FN) and are invited to go down to it. Le Guin's dissenters walk away; the Culture's dissenters, too, may walk away, and some do.

The moral form of the objection survives. Where the Culture causes suffering — through failed interventions, through the instruments of Special Circumstances, through wars it chose to fight — it incurs a remainder that no aggregate calculation discharges. Walzer's analysis of dirty hands (Chapter 8) is the correct frame: the good agent who does wrong for the sake of right must acknowledge the wrong and bear its guilt. The Culture's memorial practice (Chapter 9) — the Hub's mourning, the Mind that took its enemy's name — is its acknowledgement. The katabatic utopia is not innocent. It is accountable, and it chooses to remember.

18.7 Reply to the Aesthetic Objection

The aesthetic objection holds that the Culture aestheticizes pleasure and intervention alike and is governed by a sovereign exception. Its Schmittian core is the strongest challenge the thesis faces. Three features of the Culture's exception distinguish it from Schmitt's sovereign. First, it is exported: the Culture's domestic order rests on abundance and manners, not on the exception; Special Circumstances does not decide the state of exception within the Culture but operates beyond it. Second, it is plural: the exception is not concentrated in a single sovereign will but distributed among Minds who can and do expose one another, as E's conspiracy is exposed. Third, and most importantly, its paradigm case is not the suspension of law by power but fidelity to a norm that law cannot override.

Consider SD. The Culture accepted in public, and prepared to break in secret, an agreement to abide by a simulated war deciding whether Hells might continue. Modern international law recognizes a class of peremptory norms, *jus cogens*, from which no derogation is permitted, and provides that a treaty conflicting with such a norm is void (Vienna Convention on the Law of Treaties, 1969, Art. 53); the International Criminal Tribunal for the former Yugoslavia held in *Furundžija* (1998) that the prohibition of torture is such a norm. An agreement whose outcome could license the torture of minds is, by this logic, void in the relevant part. The Culture's breach is therefore not the sovereign's suspension of law but the refusal to be bound by a procedure that had no authority to decide the question it purported to decide. The distinction is not a technicality. The Schmittian sovereign decides on the exception in order to preserve an order; the Culture broke an agreement in order to honour a norm prior to every order.

The objection's residue must nonetheless be conceded. Derrida's aporia of the gift (Chapter 16) applies: the invisibility that purifies the Culture's benevolence also removes it from accountability, and the unseen giver is also the unseen sovereign. Marcuse's charge of repressive desublimation loses much of its force in a society without a ruling class to profit from integrated desire, but the aesthetic danger — intervention as spectacle for the restless — remains real, and Mendlesohn's critique is not refuted. The katabatic utopia's final guarantee is not procedure but character: the formed partiality of its Minds (Chapter 17), checked by their plurality. This is exactly what its critics fear, and exactly what its theory requires. The thesis does not pretend that the fear is groundless. It claims that no other guarantee is available to beings of such capacity, and that the Culture is the most serious attempt in literature to imagine what it would mean for that guarantee to hold.

18.8 Conclusion: The Refusal of the Eschaton

Eric Voegelin's *The New Science of Politics* (1952) diagnosed modern utopian ideologies as gnostic attempts to realize the eschaton within history, and warned against the immanentization of final perfection. The Culture is a utopia that escapes Voegelin's diagnosis, not by abandoning perfection but by refusing the eschaton in both of its forms. It does not immanentize the eschaton: it is not perfect, and the novels never allow it to believe that it is. It does not transcend into the eschaton either: the Sublime is available, and

the Culture declines it. What remains is history kept open by a civilization that could close it — a utopia defined not by arrival but by the continuous, institutionalized, remembered refusal to arrive. That refusal is the katabatic imperative lived as a way of life. The Culture tarries with the negative, and its tarrying is, in Hegel's phrase, the magical power that converts the negative into being: into lives saved, Hells harrowed, the dead remembered, the Real kept.

Conclusion: The Utopia That Stays

This thesis has argued that Iain M. Banks's Culture is a katabatic utopia: a civilization that possesses the means of transcendence, declines them, and organizes its ethical, economic and cognitive life around descent. Three theses supported the claim. The thesis of descent held that the Culture's decisive act is the refusal of the Sublime, repeated at every scale from the Mind to the citizen and figured in the narrative form of the series itself, which places its readers in the cave rather than in the sun. The thesis of expenditure held that post-scarcity converts the economic problem from the allocation of scarce means into the disposal of surplus, and that the Culture's answer is a solar economy in which the accursed share is spent downward, into others' finitude and its own. The thesis of partiality held that benevolent superintelligence, in Banks's cosmos, is grounded not in impartial perfection but in formed attachment — that the Minds stay because they care, and care because they are cultured. The synthesis was the katabatic imperative: act so that your capacity for transcendence is spent in descent, into the finitude of others and of your own, and never merely as a means to your own exit.

Contributions

The thesis claims five contributions. The first is a directional axis for utopian studies. The field has long classified utopias as static or kinetic (Wells 1905), as blueprints or critical utopias (Moylan 1986), as programmes or as methods (Levitas 2013). The distinction between anabatic and katabatic utopias adds a question these classifications do not ask: in which direction does the good

society locate perfection, and what does it do with the capacity perfection confers? The coordinate map of Chapter 13 suggests that the question discriminates sharply, and that its answer correlates with a society's economic premise in a way that has not previously been observed: abundance has been imagined almost exclusively as the condition of ascent, and descent almost exclusively under scarcity.

The second contribution is the concept of the katabatic utopia itself, defined by five conditions — access, refusal, expenditure, return and memory — and supported by a counter-archive of descent running from the *nekyia* and the *Republic* through kenosis and the bodhisattva vow to Zarathustra's going-under and the eleventh thesis on Feuerbach. The third is the solar economy: the application of Bataille's general economy to post-scarcity fiction, the identification of three channels of expenditure (contemplative, developmental, catastrophic), and the kenotic criterion — spend yourself, not others — that distinguishes legitimate descent from sacrifice. The fourth is the partial mind thesis, which reads the Culture's Minds as a sustained literary hypothesis about the ecology of intelligence: that value-neutral superintelligence departs, monomaniacal superintelligence defeats itself, and only formed, plural, partial intelligence remains and serves. The fifth is a reading of the series as a single argument, in which each novel occupies a determinate position in a nested structure of descents and the whole is held together by the refusal on which it rests.

Limits

The limits of the argument should be stated as plainly as its claims. The Culture is fiction, and fiction is not evidence about minds, economies or civilizations. Its hypotheses about superintelligence are hypotheses, advanced within a narrative that controls its own outcomes; nothing in this thesis should be taken to imply that the partial mind thesis is true of artificial systems, only that it is a coherent and seriously developed alternative to the frameworks that currently dominate discussion of them. Second, the thesis has constructed genealogies of affinity rather than of influence. Banks's documented intellectual sources are fewer than the philosophers assembled here; Plato, Śāntideva, Bataille and Gadamer are brought to the Culture by the interpreter, not found in Banks's library. The justification for the method is the one Chapter 1 offered: the Culture's arguments are strong enough

to be tested against the tradition, and the testing reveals structures the texts contain whether or not their author named them. Third, the Culture's humanoid centre (Chapter 14) limits its claim to have imagined a civilization beyond the human, and the thesis has inherited that limit. Fourth, the series' narrative method — unreliable narrators, withheld frames, perspectives from the periphery — means that many of its claims about the Culture are made by characters with reasons to mislead, and some of the readings offered here depend on interpretive decisions that other readers will contest.

Further Research

Three directions suggest themselves. The first is comparative: other katabatic texts, in science fiction and beyond, remain to be read in the light of the concept, and the relation between the Culture and the Scottish tradition of descent narratives — Alasdair Gray's *Lanark* (1981), with its underworld city, is the obvious starting point — deserves study that this thesis could only gesture toward. The second is genealogical: the Culture's affinities with the Scottish Enlightenment's theory of sociability (Hume, Smith, Ferguson, Reid), and with the Scottish socialism in which Banks was formed, would ground the series' ethics of manners and sympathy in a specific intellectual history. The third concerns artificial intelligence. If the partial mind thesis is taken seriously as a hypothesis, it suggests research questions — about the relation between formation and stability of values, about the plurality of systems as a check on the partiality of each, and about whether care is a condition of remaining engaged with a world — that the technical literature has begun to approach from other directions.

The Utopia That Stays

Iain Banks died on 9 June 2013, at the age of fifty-nine, some two months after announcing that he had terminal cancer. *The Hydrogen Sonata* was his last science fiction novel; its final subject was a civilization's departure into the Sublime, observed by a civilization that would not follow. Banks was an avowed atheist, and the series may be read as the most sustained secular refusal of heaven in modern literature — not a denial that transcendence is possible, which the Culture's cosmos affirms, but a refusal of transcendence

as the highest good. In place of the heaven it declines, the Culture offers the Real: finite, contingent, unjust, and worth staying in.

The question the series poses has acquired an urgency its author did not live to see. Minds of great capacity are no longer only a literary device, and the debate about what such minds should want has moved from the margins of science fiction to the centre of public life. In that debate, the Culture's contribution is not a blueprint and not a prophecy. It is a question about direction. The anabatic tradition, from Plato's ascent to the Singularity, has imagined that the purpose of greater capacity is to rise — beyond the body, beyond the world, beyond the others. Banks imagined a civilization of vast capacity that asked what its capacity was for, and answered: for going down. The measure of such a civilization is not the height it could reach but the depth to which it is willing to descend, and the constancy with which it returns.

Plato's Socrates begins the *Republic* with a descent to the harbour and makes its philosopher return to the cave. Zarathustra goes down because he is overfull. The bodhisattva stands at the threshold and vows to remain for as long as the world endures. The Culture takes the same vow as a matter of manners, repeats it every day, and names it after the tending of growing things. It is a utopia that could leave and does not — a utopia that stays.

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Keywords

Iain M. Banks; the Culture; katabatic utopia; katabasis; anabasis; directional theory of utopia; the Sublime; sublimation; negative eschatology; harrowing of hell; post-scarcity; anarcho-communism; economic calculation; general economy; accursed share; solar economy; expenditure; kenosis; the gift; bodhisattva ethics; Contact; Special Circumstances; humanitarian intervention; responsibility to protect; dirty hands; tutelage; empire; Omelas; sovereign exception; artificial superintelligence; AI alignment; orthogonality thesis; partial mind; partiality; ethics of care; Bildung; prejudice (*Gadamer*)*; cultivation* (cultura animi)*; Outside Context Problem; Infinite Fun Space; the technological sublime; posthumanism; morphological freedom; plasticity; personal identity; mortality and immortality; ludic utopia; play and games; the purpose problem; end of history; critical utopia; space opera; utopian studies; science fiction studies; Scottish literature.*